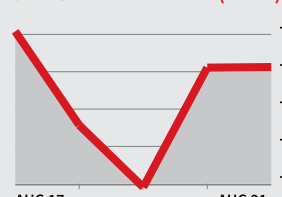


# the hindu businessline

**SENSEX** 77540.83 (+3.11)



**IN FOCUS**

|                       | LATEST    | CHANGE |
|-----------------------|-----------|--------|
| Nifty 50              | 24252.00  | +20.15 |
| P/E Ratio (Sensex)    | 20.54     | 0      |
| US Dollar (in ₹)      | 95.69     | -0.01  |
| Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹) | 159977.00 | +3526  |
| Silver 1 kg (in ₹)    | 246630.00 | +8864  |

## SWEET SLUMP.

**Sugar resale prices** fell ₹400-500 a quintal after the government approved 1 mt of duty-free raw sugar imports **p8**



## AUTO FOCUS.

**The BMW X1 LWB** delivers exceptional space, luxury and refined performance **p4**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

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## QUICKLY.

### ONE MORE HIKE

**Tata Motors PV to up rates by ₹25,000 from Sept**



**Mumbai:** Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles on Friday said it will raise prices of its cars and SUVs by up to ₹25,000 from September 1, marking its third revision in five months as rising input costs squeeze margins ahead of the festive season. For some Harrier and Safari variants, the revision could potentially push the cumulative increase since April beyond ₹50,000. **p2**

### MANPOWER ADVANTAGE

**‘CDSCO to step up audit of medical device makers’**

**New Delhi:** The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation will significantly step up audits and inspections of medical device manufacturers as the regulator gets additional manpower, said Drug Controller-General of India Rajeev Raghuvanshi at the CII Global MedTech Summit on Friday. He said over the past two years, the CDSCO was mainly issuing permissions and licences because of resource constraints. **p3**

# Centre notifies ₹62,500 crore mobile phone making scheme

**AATMANIRBHAR.** Scheme gives a 1.5% incentive for local sourcing of key components

**S Ronendra Singh**  
New Delhi

The Centre on Friday notified the ₹62,500 crore Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS) to provide production-linked incentives (PLI) for making in India and to support Indian brands.

The scheme aims to increase India's global competitiveness by further enhancing scale and deepening the mobile manufacturing supply chain through higher DVA and stronger domestic manufacturing capabilities, said Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister of Electronics and Information Technology.

### TWO SEGMENTS

The government is targeting two segments under the scheme: Target Segment 1 (TS1), which incentivises mobile phone manufacturing and TS2 that supports Indian brands.

The scheme will run for five years, effective from April 1, 2026 (FY 2026-27) to FY 2030-31. Applicants under TS2 may be granted a gestation period of one year.

Mobile phone manufacturers, including Electronics



**PROVIDING A BOOST.** IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw at the launch of the Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme on Friday **ANI**

Manufacturing Services (EMS), registered in India with a minimum turnover of ₹10,000 crore in FY26, will be eligible under the scheme, the notification said. It also stated that firms with 51 per cent Indian ownership and a turnover of ₹1,000 crore in FY26 will be eligible as well.

### NO MINIMUM SALE NORM

“There shall not be any minimum ‘threshold sales’ requirement for Indian brands. Selection of the Indian brands for eligibility under the scheme shall be done by the empowered committee,” the notification said.

To further accelerate domestic manufacturing and ensure *aatmanirbharta* in the

mobile phone manufacturing ecosystem, the scheme also provides an additional incentive of up to 1.5 per cent for domestic sourcing of key components and sub-assemblies, provided that such components are localised for a minimum of 25 per cent of the mobile phone units manufactured in a financial year.

According to MeitY, cumulative mobile phone production in the country is expected to reach around ₹39 lakh crore, with a significant increase in exports during the tenure of the scheme. The MPMS is also expected to generate around 60,000 direct jobs, contributing to economic growth and strengthening India's position as a

global electronics manufacturing hub.

“By providing up to a 1.5 per cent additional incentive for localising critical sub-assemblies such as camera modules, display assemblies, mechanics and battery cells, alongside an unprecedented 3 per cent incentive for domestic R&D and product design under TS2 of local brands creation, the MPMS creates a direct pathway to scale indigenous IP and foster champion Indian mobile brands,” said Ashok Chandak, President, India Electronics and Semiconductor Association.

### RISE IN PRICES

In response to a question from *businessline* about the rising prices of smartphones in the recent past and whether such schemes would help control prices in the future, Vaishnaw stated that it was a global phenomenon as more chips are being allocated to AI data centres. “As we manufacture more memory chips, like Micron plant is manufacturing memory chips... there are so many players who are increasing their capacity... so this will also stabilise.”

## Retail F&O participants get younger; 88.5% of under-30 traders lost money

**Akshata Gorde**  
Mumbai

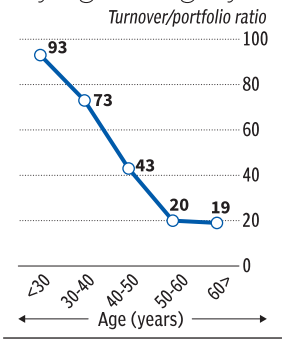
India's retail F&O market is getting younger, with traders below 40 now accounting for nearly four out of every five individual participants while generating over half of derivatives turnover despite holding just 29 per cent of the aggregate equity portfolio of individual F&O traders.

Traders below 30 accounted for 32.83 lakh, or 43 per cent, of individual F&O traders in FY26, up from 31 per cent in FY22, making them the largest group in the segment.

Another 35 per cent were aged between 30 and 40, taking the share of traders below 40 to 78 per cent, according to SEBI's latest F&O study.

The intensity of their participation moved in reverse to their age, with traders below 30 generating turnover worth 93 times the value of their equity portfolios in FY26, compared with 73 times for those aged between 30 and 40. For traders aged 50 and above, the ratio was about 20 times. Traders with higher turnover relative to their equity portfolios tended to report a higher incidence of losses and greater average losses per trader.

### Trading intensity by age category



Source: SEBI

The younger cohort, however, was not the biggest contributor to aggregate losses. Traders aged between 30 and 40 lost ₹36,642 crore in FY26, accounting for 41 per cent of individual traders' total losses. Traders below 30 lost ₹19,287 crore, or 22 per cent.

About 88.55 per cent of traders below 30 lost money compared with 88.05 per cent of those aged between 30 and 40. However, the average loss was substantially higher for the latter at ₹1,36,418, compared with ₹58,749 for traders below 30.

### HARD BITE LESSONS

The lure of quick gains continues to attract young traders despite the high odds of losses. A 33-year-old en-

gineer-turned-full-time trader said the possibility of outsized returns kept him in the market. “Even though I knew the odds were against me, once I managed to make more than 10 per cent on the money put in within a week, the hope of the potential upside kept me going,” he said.

Looking back, he acknowledged that the occasional winning trade masked his overall losses. “I may have made more losses per trade in total, but those one-off profits softened the blow and kept me coming back,” he said.

Not all traders stayed the course. A 29-year-old trader said he exited the derivatives market after SEBI tightened F&O regulations. Having consistently incurred losses, he saw little reason to continue. “I was mostly making losses. After the new rules kicked in, I decided to stop trading derivatives altogether,” he said.

The rise in younger participation comes against the backdrop of a sharp expansion in India's retail market over the past few years.

A top retail broker said the firm saw the largest increase in new accounts during the 2023-24 equity market rally, when the strong rise in equities attracted more young investors and traders to the market.

## Colgate-Palmolive names Manish Anandani CEO; Prabha Narasimhan elevated to regional role

**Amit Vijay Mohile**  
Mumbai

Colgate-Palmolive India reached into its past for its next CEO. The oral-care leader brought back 13-year company veteran Manish Anandani as Managing Director and CEO, effective September 28, succeeding current CEO Prabha Narasimhan, who is moving on to a larger Asia-Pacific role. Anandani's task is firmly focused on the future: Finding Colgate-Palmolive India's next growth engine.

He inherits some unfinished business. Days before the new CEO announcement, Narasimhan acknowledged during an August 17 analyst call that Palmolive had underperformed. “We haven't done a great job with Palmolive,” she said.



Manish Anandani

Global CEO Noel Wallace had earlier acknowledged that the India business had become “distracted” by its Ayurveda push. Yet, this is not a conventional turnaround story. Colgate stated that its premium portfolio grew five times faster than the broader market during Narasimhan's tenure.

Nuvama welcomed Anandani's appointment, stating that the leadership “overhang goes away”, and highlighting his expertise in sales, marketing and e-commerce.

### BETTING ON TWO INDIAS

The bigger challenge is managing two Indias. One segment buys toothpaste through neighbourhood stores, where ₹10 and ₹20 packs remain critical; the other is trading up to specialised oral-care products and increasingly shopping through e-commerce and quick commerce channels. Premium toothpaste accounts for less than 19 per cent of the category, leaving considerable headroom for growth.

There is another growth opportunity: Increasing consumption itself.

“About 76 per cent of urban Indians and 45 per cent of rural consumers still do not brush twice daily, while the average toothbrush replacement period is around nine months.

For the market leader, encouraging existing consumers to use more oral-care products can be just as important as gaining market share,” said an industry analyst tracking the sector.

“Anandani knows the Colgate machine, but he returns to a very different consumer market,” said Kranti Bhatini, Director, Equity Strategy at WealthMills Securities.

Anandani has been with Kenvue which he joined after a 13-year stint with Colgate-Palmolive from 2005 to 2018.

He was elevated to Managing Director at Kenvue in 2022.

## REHEARSING THE RESPONSE



**READY FOR RESCUE.** Southern Railway personnel take part in a safety drill simulating a train accident at the goods shed area in Tiruchirappalli, Tamil Nadu, on Friday. Railway officials said a derailment of two AC and one general coach was staged. Various departments of the Railways, including the RPF and medical teams, swung into action. Informed of the ‘accident’, the NDRF deployed 30 personnel. Accident relief trains and a medical relief van with an operation theatre and 10 beds were also deployed **ANI**

## Welspun wins \$1.8 b US pipe order, its biggest ever

**Our Bureau**  
Ahmedabad

Welspun Corp has landed a roughly \$1.8 billion (about ₹17,200 crore) US pipe order, its largest-ever single contract.

The development puts the company at the centre of the next leg of America's gas infrastructure expansion and gives it revenue visibility through 2030.

The order, comprising LSAW (longitudinal submerged arc welded) and spiral pipes, is linked to a project to move natural gas from the Permian Basin to the US Gulf coast. The order comes against the backdrop of sustained demand for large-diameter pipes in the US, supported by natural gas pipeline infrastructure and the expansion of LNG exports.

Permian Basin is among the US' key oil and gas producing regions, and infrastructure connecting production to the Gulf Coast.



The order is linked to moving natural gas from the Permian Basin in the US to the country's Gulf coast

BK Goenka, Chairman, Welspun World, said in a company release.

The size of the order, he added, reinforces the company's strategy and positions it to participate in the next phase of energy-infrastructure development in the US.

The company said its US manufacturing operations will play a key role in executing the order.

### SUSTAINED DEMAND

Welspun expects strong demand to continue, with the US market also seeing spending linked to data centres and energy infrastructure, said a report by Nuvama Research.

The company expects its US order book to provide significant execution visibility over the next few years. Nuvama said the project, along with one or two additional projects in nearby regions, could support further order opportunities for Welspun. The company currently has around 3.5 million tonnes of volume capacity in the US, which it aims to

double over the next two years. A new plant is also expected to become operational from December.

Importantly, the management does not currently envisage another major capex programme beyond the ongoing investments.

### EBITDA GROWTH

The latest win sharply increases Welspun's order book from about ₹25,300 crore at the end of Q1 FY27.

Around 60-65 per cent of the current order book is from the US, with the US component expected to be executed over the next three to three-and-a-half years.

Nuvama estimates the company's US line-pipe volumes could grow 25 per cent in FY27, 35 per cent in FY28, and 30 per cent in FY29. The management has indicated that it continues to target ₹2,800 crore of EBITDA in FY27 and believes doubling EBITDA by FY30 is achievable if all geographies perform well.

Interview on **p2**

## Joyalukkas, Kalyan bag TN order for 4.41 lakh rings to newborns

The jewellers pipped others for the ₹755-crore order by bidding on a razor-thin margin

**Chitra Narayanan**  
**Sindhu Hariharan**  
Kochi/Chennai

Making 4.41 lakh gold rings may sound like a massive order for most jewellers, but for Kerala-based Joyalukkas and Kalyan Jewellers, it is a chance to combine economies of scale, brand visibility and public welfare.

The two jewellers have pipped a crop of regional rivals to emerge as the lowest bidder (L1) for the Tamil Nadu government's ₹755-crore welfare initiative: Thai Maman Thanga Mothiram Thittam.

The State government said in a statement that once Joyalukkas bid the lowest, the other 10 participating companies were asked to indicate their acceptance by comparing their prices with the quota-



The two jewellers will supply 1 g gold rings from June 22 till the end of the current financial year

tion submitted by the lowest bidder, as is the norm, and Kalyan Jewellers was the only company that agreed to match the quoted price.

Thereafter, work orders were issued in a 70:30 ratio to the selected lowest bidders, Joyalukkas and Kalyan Jewellers, to provide 1,28,499 rings for the first four months, the statement added.

The cost of gold will be borne by the government of Tamil Nadu at the prevailing market rate.

Asked about the economics of the bid, Joy Alukkas, CMD of the Joyalukkas Group, told *businessline* that the decision to participate went beyond the commercial aspect, and the company was happy to contribute its capabilities toward a scheme with a strong social purpose.

“We see this as an opportunity to create long-term value while leveraging our brand strength, retail experience and established customer base,” he added.

### BRAND VISIBILITY

Industry stakeholders said that the financial hit to the companies may not be much given the benefits of the scale of production, especially as the rings are ex-

pected to be standardised and involve limited design work. On the other hand, the contract could provide them with significant brand visibility and reach across Tamil Nadu, the source added.

However, others felt that the financial losses could be much higher, as manufacturing cost is roughly 3-4 per cent of the gold cost, but it will help the company in brand recognition and goodwill, and they will likely offset costs from their inventory since gold prices have gone up in the past few days.

“The State is a key market for us, and we see potential to further strengthen our presence and serve customers,” Alukkas said.

With inputs from Subramani Ra  
Mancombu in Chennai



QUICKLY.

Shriram Wealth plans to expand HNI client base



**Mumbai:** Shriram Wealth plans to expand beyond its existing HNI client base and target customers with investable assets of ₹10 lakh to ₹2 crore over the next 12-18 months, MD and CEO Vikas Satija told *PTI* on Friday. The company currently focuses on clients in the ₹2-25 crore segment, and will gradually look at serving a wider set of customers with the wealth management solutions, he said. **PTI**

Poonawalla Fincorp raises ₹150 crore via Tier II NCDs

**Mumbai:** Poonawalla Fincorp Ltd on Friday allotted 15,000 unsecured, subordinated NCDs, raising ₹150 crore at an annual coupon rate of 8.4308 per cent. The NCDs, each with a face value of ₹1 lakh, mature in April 2036. The aggregate amount received stood at ₹153.54 crore, including accrued interest of ₹4.12 crore and a discount of ₹57.97 lakh. Poonawalla Fincorp shares closed at ₹490.05 on the NSE, down 0.81 per cent from the previous close. **OUR BUREAU**

Hexaware bets on AI to capture SaaS spending

Our Bureau  
Chennai

Mid-tier IT-services firm Hexaware aims to capture a larger share of the IT-spend pool by leveraging AI to help enterprises build custom software instead of relying on traditional SaaS vendors. Speaking at a media roundtable during the company's AI day in Chennai on Friday, CEO R Srikrishna suggested that with AI, it is no longer expensive or time-consuming to build custom software. "The global SaaS market is around \$900 billion. You do not need to replace all of it. There will be some people who do not want to switch, some who can not change for regulatory and compliance reasons. But we see that there are enough people who do want to change things," he said. Hexaware launched its 'Zero license' enterprise offering earlier this year to help organisations replace bloated SaaS workflows.

TOKEN EXPENSES

Most of the token spend for custom-AI solutions will be a

Tata Motors PV to hike car rates by ₹25,000 from Sept

**CRITICAL TIME.** The third price revision since April comes as festival season approaches

Amit Vijay Mohile  
Mumbai

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles on Friday said it will raise prices of its cars and SUVs by up to ₹25,000 from September 1, marking its third revision in five months as rising input costs squeeze margins ahead of the festive season. For some Harrier and Safari variants, the revision could potentially push the cumulative increase since April beyond ₹50,000.

The timing puts Tata Motors PV's pricing power to an important test; the automaker is seeking to recover costs just as festive-season buying puts vehicle affordability and loan repayments under greater scrutiny.

RIVALS RAISE PRICES

Tata Motors PV isn't alone. Hyundai Motor India, which raised prices by 0.6 per cent in January and by up to ₹12,800 from June 1, will implement another hike of up to 1 per cent in September.

Maruti Suzuki has already announced increases of up to ₹30,000 twice since June, while offering price protection on some entry-level



**BEARING THE BRUNT.** The pricing action is courtesy of commodity inflation squeezing margins and the automaker wanting to pass on the costs to customers **REUTERS**

models. Mahindra & Mahindra also has taken steeper increases, raising ICE SUV prices by up to 2.5 per cent from April 6, with an average portfolio increase of 1.6 per cent, followed by an average 2.7 per cent increase from July 10.

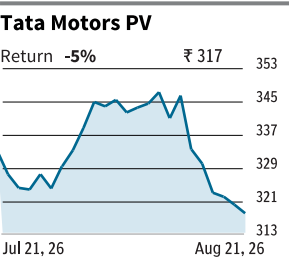
BIGGEST IMPACT

Tata Motors PV began its current pricing cycle on April 1 with a weighted-average 0.5 per cent increase across its ICE portfolio. It followed that with an increase of up to 1.5 per cent across ICE and EV models from July 1. The management subsequently said its average price action was 0.5 per cent in both April and July, implying a cumulative portfolio-level increase of about 1 per cent through

July. The actual impact, however, has varied sharply by model and variant.

Published price comparisons show selected Harrier variants became costlier by up to ₹22,000 in July, while some Safari variants rose by up to ₹21,000. Price of the Nexon increased by as much as ₹15,000, while increases on the Punch and Curvv were not as steep.

If the Harrier and Safari variants, which received the largest July increases, attract the full ₹25,000 September revision, their July-September increase alone could reach ₹47,000 and ₹46,000, respectively. Any applicable April increase could push the cumulative rise beyond ₹50,000. That remains an upper-bound estimate.



Tata is yet to disclose its September model- and variant-wise price list and has said the increase will vary across its portfolio.

COST PRESSURES

"While TMPV continues to absorb a significant portion of these increases, a part of the impact is being passed on to customers through this adjustment," the company said. The pricing action comes as commodity inflation squeezes margins. Tata Motors PV said the June-quarter inflation had an impact equivalent to about 4.5 per cent of domestic-busines revenue, with another 3 per cent hardening expected in the September quarter.

CFO Dhiman Gupta had earlier told analysts that Tata Motors PV would take "further calibrated increases through the year".

Grasim Industries targets ₹2-lakh cr revenue in FY27

Our Bureau  
Mumbai

Grasim Industries will reach revenue of ₹2-lakh crore in this financial year, aided by a sharp growth in its legacy business and new-age ventures. That's nearly double the topline it posted five years ago.

In FY26, the company registered its highest-ever consolidated revenue of ₹1.75-lakh crore. The company is positioned at the intersection of many of the country's most important growth vectors — housing, infrastructure, consumption, financial inclusion, digital commerce, sustainability, and clean energy, Chairman Kumar Mangalam Birla said at Grasim's 79<sup>th</sup> annual general meeting on Friday.

HUGE INVESTMENTS

Over the past five years, Grasim has invested nearly ₹74,000 crore in capital expenditure to build and beautify homes, cement infrastructure growth, enable sustainable fashion, support industrial growth, expand



Kumar Mangalam Birla, Chairman, Grasim Industries

financial inclusion, digitise commerce, and power the clean-energy transition.

Housing, urbanisation, infrastructure development, and rising consumer aspirations are creating a long runway for growth. Through UltraTech Cement, Birla Opus, and Birla Pivot, Grasim now has a deeper, more integrated presence across this ecosystem, said Birla.

For instance, paint brand Birla Opus has doubled its revenue in two years and achieved a 10 per cent revenue market share on a standalone basis in FY26. It is already the number two player by capacity. Along with the Birla White putty

business, Grasim's revenue market share has reached the early teens in the Indian decorative-paints market, he said.

Birla Pivot, the B2B e-commerce platform for building materials, has surpassed its annual revenue guidance of ₹8,500 crore.

CAPACITY EXPANSION

On the core business, Lyocell is emerging as one of the most prominent next-gen cellulosic fibres. The business is further strengthening its future readiness through an investment of nearly ₹4,000 crore, expanding its fibre capacity by nearly five times, said Birla.

Aditya Birla Renewables, which was a 2 GW platform not so long ago, has transformed into a national-scale renewable-energy business with clear visibility of around 10 GW.

The recently announced acquisition of Sprng Energy has added about 5 GW of peak contracted renewable capacity and broadens the platform with its strong commercial and industrial franchise, he added.

Energy-infra opportunity in US is structural, not one-off: Welspun CEO

bl.interview

Avinash Nair  
Ahmedabad

Welspun Corp's ₹17,200 crore order has put its US business at the centre of the company's next growth phase. The contract takes its global order book to about \$4.4 billion. For MD and CEO Vipul Mathur, however, the bigger story is what the order says about Welspun's US strategy.

The company believes its local manufacturing footprint in the US and capacity investments have positioned it for a broader North American energy-infrastructure spending.

*Edited excerpts:*

What enabled Welspun to win an order of this scale? Was the company's US manufacturing footprint a decisive factor?

This is one of the biggest and most prestigious orders in the history of Welspun. At this stage, we are not disclosing the customer details.

Our local manufacturing presence in the US has been a key advantage. Over the years, we have invested in building capacity closer to our customers.

For critical infrastructure

“

The demand remains strong, and we are seeing multiple large and complex projects at different stages of development and execution

VIPUL MATHUR  
MD and CEO, Welspun Corp



projects of this nature, local manufacturing significantly strengthens the company's competitiveness.

What does the order tell you about the opportunity in the US energy-infrastructure market?

We see this as part of a broader structural opportunity in the North American energy-infrastructure market, rather than a one-off project. There are multiple large-scale projects under consideration, particularly in key energy hubs such as the Permian Basin.

This order reinforces our positioning to participate in the next phase of energy-infrastructure development in the US.

Does Welspun need additional capex to execute the order?

The order will be executed through our existing manufacturing facilities. We continue to focus on debottlenecking and targeted capacity augmentation to strengthen our ability to address future opportunities.

We believe our planned capex and augmentation initiatives will provide us with sufficient flexibility to participate in the opportunities we see in the market. As the pipeline develops, we will continue to assess capacity requirements accordingly.

What kind of visibility does the order give Welspun?

More than 60-65 per cent of the business will be executed from the US, with the overall order book to be executed over the next three to three-and-a-half years. The order book provides revenue visibility through FY28 and FY29.

● **RISKS REMAIN**

Demand could moderate in H2 FY27 owing to the potential El Niño impact and elevated fuel prices

and costlier powertrains, premiumisation is helping companies and dealers generate more revenue without increasing sales.

The trend is expected to continue in FY27. Crisil expects volumes to grow another 8-10 per cent this fiscal.

BEYOND THE SALE

The shift means dealerships are becoming progressively less reliant on the initial vehicle transaction. A growing installed base gives dealers opportunities to generate recurring income through servicing and spares, while insurance and accessories provide additional revenue.

"The earnings mix of PV dealers is also improving. Sustained sales growth has expanded the base for ancillary income, increasing its

share of revenues by around 200 basis points over the past three years to approximately 16 per cent in FY26," said Himank Sharma, Director, Crisil Ratings.

The changing revenue mix, combined with higher volumes and better fixed-cost absorption, is expected to lift dealer operating margins to 3.5-3.7 per cent in FY27, from around 3.3 per cent last fiscal.

Dealers, however, have considerably more financial breathing room than a year earlier because inventories have fallen sharply.

EASING PRESSURE

Inventory levels declined to 30-35 days as of March 2026, from 50-55 days a year earlier and are expected to remain around 30 days at the end of FY27. This improves working-capital efficiency and limits incremental borrowing requirements for dealers.

But there are risks to the growth outlook. Rural demand could moderate in the second half because of the potential El Niño impact and elevated fuel prices linked to tensions in West Asia.

De Havilland Canada sees strong traction for seaplanes in India

Rohit Vaid  
New Delhi

India's decision to allow the import of 20-year-old seaplanes has drawn a "measured but optimistic" response from Canadian aircraft manufacturer De Havilland Canada. The company said the regulatory shift will enable operators to induct capacity at a faster rate and lower capital cost.

The global market offers a large pool of well-maintained Twin Otter aircraft above the 20-year mark, making this a "pragmatic and enabling step" for India's nascent seaplane ecosystem, Yogesh Garg, Regional Vice President of Sales, Asia, Middle East and Africa, De Havilland Canada, told *businessline*.

On the other hand, while the move accelerates early adoption, older seaplanes demand disciplined airworthiness oversight, corrosion management, and strict adherence to original equipment manufacturer (OEM) standards, particularly in



Small aircraft will be central to India's next aviation growth cycle

YOGESH GARG  
Regional V-P Sales  
(Asia, Middle East and Africa)

amphibious environments, he added. At present, several regional players have shown interest in operating seaplane services connecting the mainland to the island territories of Lakshadweep. Currently, no such service exists in India.

POSITIVE REFORMS

Garg identified three structural enablers required for India to scale seaplane operations sustainably.

First is the need for regulatory clarity, including faster water drome approvals, standardised operating procedures and specialised pilot-training pathways, he said, noting that the DGCA has already introduced several reforms. Infrastructure readiness, such as floating docks, emergency-response systems, maintenance access, refuelling support, and weather monitoring tailored to water operations, was cited as the second requirement. The third, he said, is commercial support through viability-gap funding in the initial phase, customised financing solutions and a structured training ecosystem.

SMALL INFRA

Garg said the government's focus on seaplanes as well as small aircraft will stimulate aviation growth on thin passenger traffic routes in the country. As India expands its network of airstrips and water dromes, small aircraft will form the backbone of rural, remote, and tourism-driven air services, he added.

BMW launches X1 long wheelbase at ₹49.9 lakh



**MORE LEGROOM.** With a length of over 4.6 m, the X1 is the longest and among the spacious 5-seater SUVs in India, BMW said

Our Bureau  
New Delhi

Luxury carmaker BMW Group India on Friday launched the X1 long wheelbase (LWB) at a starting price of ₹49.9 lakh (ex-show-room). The luxury sports activity vehicle, X1 LWB, is locally produced at the company's plant in Chennai in a petrol variant, the company said.

"The BMW X1 had re-defined success in the luxury SUV segment in India by consistently delivering the perfect blend of performance, versatility and premium ownership. With the new BMW X1 long

wheelbase, we have taken that winning formula further," Hardeep Singh Brar, President and CEO, BMW Group India, said.

He said the new X1 can also take ethanol-blended petrol of up to 25 per cent (E25). The BMW Twin-Power Turbo technology petrol engine melds maximum power with exemplary efficiency and offers spontaneous responsiveness even at low engine speeds, the company said.

The company also unveiled the BMW i5 long wheelbase, an all-electric sedan. Prices will be announced in the next three weeks, the company said.

Anil Balaji Steel to buy steel mills in UP, Odisha

Our Bureau  
Kolkata

Anil Balaji Steel, which manufactures rolling shutter gates and steel pipes, is planning to acquire two manufacturing facilities in Uttar Pradesh and Odisha.

The Kolkata-based company is planning to increase its turnover to ₹500 crore by 2030 from the current ₹125 crore. It plans to take the SME IPO route for raising growth capital within the next three years.

"We are in talks with a couple of factories and companies. The acquisitions are expected to be completed by next year," Virendra Agarwal, CEO, Anil Balaji Steel, said on Friday. The company is already building its dealer network in the two states.

Currently, Anil Balaji Steel has a unit in West Bengal with an annual capacity of around 1 lakh tonnes.

"We have earmarked ₹100 crore investment for West Bengal and ₹50 crore each for Odisha and Uttar Pradesh in the next five years," said Agarwal.

Epigamia aims to double business in 24-30 months

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani  
New Delhi

Epigamia is eyeing an annualised revenue run rate of ₹1,000 crore by March 2028 as it plans to double its business in the next 24-30 months. This at a time when consumers are increasingly seeking healthy and protein-rich food options.

DOUBLING ARR

"We have been growing at a very high double-digit growth rate in the last two years. We have scaled up now to about annualised revenue run rate of over ₹500 crore. We expect to end the [FY27] at an ARR of over ₹700 crore and grow to over ₹1,000 crore ARR by March 2028," said Ritesh Gauba, CEO, Epigamia. "Our endeavour is to double our business every 24-30 months."

The Verlinvest-backed company has been riding on the health wave supported by quick commerce to grow. "While quick commerce's contribution ranges in the 55-60 per cent range, 35-40 per cent comes from offline.



Ritesh Gauba, CEO, Epigamia

We have a strong presence in over 150 cities," he added.

The company will be accelerating new launches while expanding its offline distribution footprint. Currently, Epigamia sells its products through about 20,000 stores. It aims to expand it to about 30,000-35,000 by next year.

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

Forex reserves swell  
\$9.9 b to \$716.9 b: RBI



**Mumbai:** India's forex reserves jumped \$9.905 billion to \$716.907 billion during the week ended August 14, the RBI said on Friday. In the previous reporting week ended August 7, the overall kitty had jumped \$14.136 billion to \$707.002 billion. Reserves had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 before the West Asia conflict that led to several weeks of a drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales. For the week ended August 14, foreign currency assets increased \$7.225 billion to \$581.851 billion. Expressed in dollar terms, foreign currency assets include the effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units held in forex reserves .m

RBI imposes penalty on Progfin, Shri Ram Fin

**Mumbai:** The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday said it has imposed a penalty on Progfin and Shri Ram Finance for non-compliance with certain provisions and directions. The central bank imposed a ₹8.1 lakh monetary penalty on Shri Ram Finance Corporation and ₹2.7 lakh on Progfin, a release said. Shri Ram Finance Corporation was penalised as it “failed to take prior written permission of the RBI while appointing a director, resulting in a change in management, on account of a change in more than 30 per cent of its directors, excluding independent directors”, it added. Progfin faced a penalty as the company failed to put in place a system of periodic review of risk categorisation of accounts, with such periodicity being at least once in six months, the release said. m

India, Singapore to boost ties in semicon, health and food trade

Our Bureau  
New Delhi

India and Singapore are set to deepen cooperation in semiconductors, digital connectivity, fintech, green hydrogen, healthcare and industrial parks while working to strengthen trade in agricultural and processed food products. The two nations seek to give greater momentum to the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. The areas of cooperation were discussed at the fourth India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR) in Singapore on Thursday, attended by senior Ministers, including Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Minister of External Affairs S Jaishankar, Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and Minister of State for Commerce & Industry and Electronics & IT Jitin Prasada, along with their Singaporean counterparts. “The Ministers noted the progress achieved under the ISMR pillars, such as significant increase in UPI-PayNow

‘CDSCO to step up audits, inspection of medical device makers in a big way’

COUNTDOWN BEGINS. Such action should not come as a surprise to companies: DCGI Rajeev Raghuvanshi

Ankita Upadhyay  
New Delhi

The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) will significantly step up audits and inspections of medical device manufacturers as the regulator gets additional manpower, said Drug Controller General of India (DCGI) Rajeev Raghuvanshi at the CII Global MedTech Summit on Friday.

**SEVERAL CONSTRAINTS** Raghuvanshi said over the past two years, since medical devices came under a more comprehensive regulatory framework, the CDSCO had focused on issuing permissions and licences to the industry because of resource constraints. Around 40,000 product licences had been issued during this period, while audits and inspections of manufac-

As we are getting more and more resources, you will see the audits in medical device industry increasing

RAJEEV RAGHUVANSHI  
Drug Controller General of India



turers had not received the same level of attention. “As we are getting more and more resources, you will see the audits in medical-device industry increasing significantly from now,” he said, adding that the industry had sufficient time to understand the regulations and prepare for compliance. He said companies should, therefore, be prepared for audits and inspections going

forward, and that such regulatory action should not come as a surprise. Raghuvanshi said the regulator was also getting additional officers. The Union Public Service Commission had recently sent a list of 20 additional medical device officers, who are expected to join in the next few months. This would double the existing strength of the med-

Poor quality medical devices being sold in India: Pharma Secy

Ankita Upadhyay  
New Delhi

Too many poor quality medical device products are being made and sold in India and the regulatory system is not able to control all of them, said Department of Pharmaceuticals Secretary Manoj Joshi, calling for stronger testing of finished devices and a regulatory framework designed specifically for the sector. Speaking at the CII Global MedTech Summit, Joshi said the problem was particularly relevant to consumer products and disposables, and quality improvements were also needed in high-end medical-device manufacturing. Joshi said the regulatory system must focus on the quality of the actual product

manufactured and not only its design. While the design of a device could be good, he said the finished product could still be substandard if the manufacturer lacked engineering capability or did not use the right raw materials. “Whether prototype or commercially made, products need to be tested. Which is not really happening much in our system,” he said.

**KEY DIFFERENCE** He said this was a fundamental difference between drugs and medical devices. Drugs were chemical or biological products, while medical devices were essentially engineering products used in healthcare. Therefore, “you require a different perspective when you do a regulation”. Joshi said a manufac-



Manoj Joshi, Secretary, Department of Pharmaceuticals

turer could make a device using the same design as a leading global company, but the final product could still be different if its engineering capabilities or raw materials are inferior. “Someone who is not very good at engineering makes the same thing, it may not be the same product,” he said. He suggested that India should consider a greater

role for third-party certification in medical device regulation. Comparing the US and European systems, he said the US model relied more on regulators doing assessments in-house and therefore required greater regulatory capability, while the European system relied more on third-party certification. “Considering where we are on the regulatory capability, probably the European model suits us better,” he said, adding that India could have greater regulatory capability in 10-15 years. Joshi also said the government must decide how components and assembly operations are regulated as devices use components from different parts of the world. He said India should not simply copy the regulatory

creasing, while imports have largely stagnated. However, he said the industry must shift from manufacturing larger volumes of relatively lower-risk products towards more sophisticated and innovative devices. **‘REVERSE TREND’** He pointed to the faster growth of Class A and B devices compared with Class C and D devices, and said that India must reverse this trend. The country must also expand its presence in higher-risk Class C and D in-vitro diagnostic devices, he said. He said only around one in seven of the medical devices approved in the country were investigational devices — those being developed without a predicate device. This, he said, was low for a country seeking to move “from volume to value” and establish itself as a hub for medical device innovation.

LOCAL PRODUCTION

Raghuvanshi said the domestic medical device industry is growing strongly, with local manufacturing in-

PNGRB okays 1,800 km of LPG pipelines with ₹7,000 crore investment

Rishi Ranjan Kala  
New Delhi

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) said on Friday that it has authorised roughly 1,800 km of new LPG pipeline infrastructure to strengthen India's energy security at an investment of ₹7,000 crore. This will expand the common carrier pipeline network to roughly 9,500 km. The pipeline infrastructure traverses Telangana, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Karnataka and Goa. India imports the bulk of its LPG supply at coastal locations, from where it needs to be transported across the country, said the regulator in a statement.

MAJOR MILESTONE

These authorisations mark another significant milestone in strengthening India's energy infrastructure. They build upon the earlier authorisation of the Kandla-Gorakhpur LPG pipeline — the country's longest LPG pipeline of around 2,757 km — and will further expand and strengthen the pipeline network, it added.

The projects also include the Cherlapally-Nagpur pipeline (556 km), Jhansi-Sitarganj pipeline (611 km) and the Shikrapur-Goa & Hubli pipeline (633 km), the regulator informed. The projects have been authorised for development by GAIL (India), and upon completion, the PNGRB-authorised common carrier LPG pipeline network in the country will increase from around 7,700 km to roughly 9,500 km, representing an increment of nearly 23.5 per cent.

‘MORE SAFETY’

“Pipeline transportation is globally recognised as the safest, most economical and environmentally sustainable mode for transporting LPG. These projects will substantially reduce the movement of LPG tank trucks, thereby improving road safety,



As the country continues to rely significantly on imported LPG, an extensive pipeline network provides inherent system resilience, the PNGRB pointed out

lowering logistics costs, reducing traffic congestion and significantly decreasing carbon emissions through a modal shift from road to pipelines,” the PNGRB emphasised.

ENERGY SECURITY

The PNGRB has been driving the agenda for the elimination of primary movement of LPG by road to bottling plants, the regulator stressed. Beyond these operational benefits, the projects assume strategic importance from the perspective of India's energy security. As the country continues to rely significantly on imported LPG, an extensive pipeline network provides inherent system resilience, it pointed out. Pipelines also function as a line-pack storage system, enabling continuous product movement, enhancing supply reliability and improving the nation's ability to respond effectively during supply disruptions, emergencies and periods of heightened demand, the PNGRB added.

Unincorporated establishments grew by over 9% in April-June

Our Bureau  
New Delhi

Unincorporated establishments grew by over 9 per cent in the April-June quarter, according to a report released by the Statistics Ministry on Friday. During this period, employment grew by over 6.5 per cent. Unincorporated establishments/enterprises refer to business units that are neither registered under the Companies Act, 1956, nor under the Companies Act, 2013. These units, ranging from small-scale manufacturers and service providers to trading establishments, constitute a significant portion of the economy. These enterprises are pivotal in generating employment, fostering entre-

preneurship and contributing to the nation's GDP. According to a quarterly report, the estimated number of establishments in April-June this fiscal stood at 8.67 crore, compared to 7.94 crore in the corresponding quarter of last fiscal, indicating a growth of 9.2 per cent. During this period, the number of employed persons in these units rose to 13.70 crore from 12.86 crore, a growth of over 6.5 per cent. “This demonstrates a healthy labour market growth in the sector [over the same quarter last year], which is a major source of employment for variety of skilled or unskilled people across different socioeconomic background,” said the report. The proportion of establishments employing hired

workers in the unincorporated non-agricultural sector was recorded at 12.13 per cent in the April-June quarter, with the percentage of workers hired on fairly regular basis estimated at 22.77 per cent. The percentage of hired-worker establishments has decreased across sectors, compared to the April-June 2025 quarter.

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‘29 FDI proposals worth ₹4,895.65 cr after easing of 10% Chinese stake rule’

Press Trust of India  
New Delhi

As many as 29 FDI proposals totalling about ₹4,895.65 crore (over \$500 million) have been reported so far following the government's decision in May to permit overseas companies with up to 10 per cent Chinese shareholding to invest in India under the automatic route, said an official statement on Friday. Before May, these companies, even with a minor stake held by an individual or

firm from a country sharing land border with India, were required to seek government approval to invest in any sector in India. Following the demand from the stakeholders, the government amended the norms. As per the amendments, foreign companies having a Chinese/Hong Kong shareholding of up to 10 per cent are eligible to invest in India in sectors where FDI is permitted under the automatic route, subject to sectoral conditions. However, these relaxed FDI rules do not ap-

ply to entities registered in China or Hong Kong or other countries sharing land borders with India. Countries that share land border with India are China, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Myanmar and Afghanistan. The Finance Ministry notified the changes to this effect under FEMA on May 1. “A total of 29 FDI investments have been reported under the revised framework up to August 20, involving proposed FDI of ₹4,895.65 crore,” said the Commerce and Industry Ministry.

**GMR AERO** (Formerly known as GMR Airports Infrastructure Limited)  
Regd. Office: Unit No - 12, 18th Floor, Tower A, Building No.5, DLF Cyber City, DLF Phase - III, Gurugram - 122002, Haryana, India  
P: +91 124 6637750, F: +91 124 6637778, E: galcoscy@gmrgroup.in, W: www.gmraero.com, (CIN): L52231HR1999PLC13564

Notice is hereby given that in accordance with SEBI circular no. HO/38/13/11/2026-MRSD-POD/ 1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, shareholders of GMR Airports Limited (formerly GMR Airports Infrastructure Limited & previously known as GMR Infrastructure Limited) are hereby informed that a special window has been opened for a period of one year starting from **February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027**, for transfer and dematerialisation ("demat") of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to February 04, 2019.

Shareholders are required to note that:

- The special window shall also be available for such transfer requests which were submitted earlier and were rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process/or otherwise.
- The securities so transferred shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Such securities shall not be transferred/lien-marked/pledged during the said lock-in period.

For clarity regarding the applicability of this special window, the following matrix may be referred to:

| Execution Date of Transfer Deed | Lodged for transfer before April 01, 2019? | Original Security Certificate Available? | Eligible to lodge in the current window? |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Before April 01, 2019           | No (fresh lodgement)                       | Yes                                      | ✓                                        |
| Before April 01, 2019           | Yes (rejected/returned earlier)            | Yes                                      | ✓                                        |
| Before April 01, 2019           | Yes                                        | No                                       | X                                        |
| Before April 01, 2019           | No                                         | No                                       | X                                        |

The procedure and conditions to be fulfilled by the Investor/Transferee/Company are detailed in the SEBI Circular referred above. Same can be accessed from the company's website at <https://www.gmraero.com/investor-relations/shareholders/special-window-relodgement-transfer-requests-physical-shares>

Shareholders who wish to avail the opportunity are requested to contact our Registrar to an Issue and Share Transfer Agent whose details are as follows:

**KFin Technologies Limited, Registered Address:** 301, The Centrum, 3rd Floor, 57, Lal Bahadur Shastri Road, Nav Pata, Kurla, (West), Mumbai, 400 070, Maharashtra. **Address for Correspondence / Operations Centre:** Selenium Building, Tower-B, Plot No 31 & 32, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Serilingampally, Hyderabad, Rangareddy, Telangana, India – 500 032. **E:** einward.ris@kfintech.com, **Toll Free Number:** 1800 309 4001, **WhatsApp Number:** (+91) 910 009 4099, **Investor Support Centre:** kpsrism.kfintech.com

Relevant shareholders are encouraged to take advantage of this special window.

For GMR Airports Limited (Formerly GMR Airports Infrastructure Limited) Sd/ T. Venkat Ramana (ACS:13979) Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: New Delhi Date: August 22, 2026

GMR GROUP-GAL/59-C/PRM ASSOCIATES

**BLACKBUCK**  
**BLACKBUCK LIMITED**  
(Formerly Known as Zinka Logistics Solutions Limited)  
Corporate Identification Number: L63030KA2015PLC079994  
Registered Office: 'Essae Vaishtavey-Summit' 1<sup>st</sup> Floor, No-6/8, 17<sup>th</sup> Main, 80 Feet Road, 3<sup>rd</sup> Block, Koramangala Industrial Layout, Corporation Ward No. 68, Koramangala, Bengaluru - 560034, Karnataka, India.  
Tel: +91 80461 22800  
E-mail: [cs@blackbuck.com](mailto:cs@blackbuck.com) Website: [www.blackbuck.com](http://www.blackbuck.com)

**NOTICE OF 14<sup>th</sup> ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING**

Members may note that the Eleventh (11<sup>th</sup>) Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of BlackBuck Limited ("**Company**") will be held on Friday, September 18, 2026 at 11:30 AM (IST), through Video Conferencing ("**VC**") / Other Audio Visual Means ("**OAVM**") in compliance with all the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("**the Act**") and the rules made thereunder, pursuant to General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("**MCA**") read with applicable Circulars issued earlier in this regard by MCA (collectively referred to as "**MCA Circulars**") and Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("**SEBI Listing Regulations**"), to transact the business(es) as set out in the Notice of the AGM. Members can attend and participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility only and their attendance shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Act.

In compliance with the above Circulars, copies of the Notice along with the Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 ("**Annual Report**") will be sent only through electronic mode to the members, whose name appears in the register of members/ register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on Friday, August 21, 2026 and whose email addresses are registered with the Company / Registrar and Share Transfer Agents ("**RTA**")/Depositories/Depository Participant(s).

A letter providing web-link for accessing the Annual Report for Financial year 2025-26 will be dispatched to those shareholders who have not registered their e-mail address with Company/Depository Participant(s)/RTA i.e. Kfin Technologies Limited ("**Kfintech**").

The Annual Report along with the Notice of AGM will also be made available on the Company's website at [www.blackbuck.com](http://www.blackbuck.com), websites of the Stock Exchanges, i.e., BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at [www.bseindia.com](http://www.bseindia.com) and [www.nseindia.com](http://www.nseindia.com) respectively and website of the RTA at <https://evoting.kfintech.com>.

The instructions for joining the AGM and the detailed procedures for e-voting will be provided in the Notice of the AGM. The facility for appointment of Proxy will not be available for the AGM.

Any Member requiring the physical copy of Notice and Annual Report may write to RTA at [einward.ris@kfintech.com](mailto:einward.ris@kfintech.com) or the Company at [cs@blackbuck.com](mailto:cs@blackbuck.com).

Members of the Company holding equity shares in physical/dematerialized form and who have not registered their email address can temporarily register their email address for the purpose of receiving Notice and Annual Report following the process as set forth in the Notice. In case of queries, shareholders may write to [evoting@kfintech.com](mailto:evoting@kfintech.com) or call at 1800 309 4001.

Members who wish to permanently register/update their email addresses with the Company may follow below instructions:

| Dematerialized Shares | Register/update the email addresses by following the process prescribed by the concerned DP.  |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Physical Shares       | Register their email ID and other KYC details with the Company or RTA through ISR Forms only. |

Once the email address is successfully registered, a copy of the Notice along with the Annual Report will be sent to the registered email address.

Further, those shareholders who have already registered their email addresses are requested to keep their e-mail addresses validated/updated with their DP/RTA to enable servicing of Notices/documents/Annual Reports and other communications electronically to their email addresses in the future.

All the Members of the Company holding equity shares in physical/dematerialized form and who have not registered their email address will have opportunity to cast their vote on the business in the manner as set forth in the Notice through remote e-voting or through e-voting system at the AGM.

Members are requested to carefully read the Notice and in particular, instructions for joining the AGM, manner of casting vote through remote e-voting or through e-voting system at the AGM.

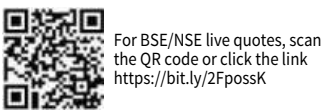
**For BlackBuck Limited**  
(Formerly known as Zinka Logistics Solutions Limited)  
Sd/-  
Barun Pandey  
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer  
Membership No: A39508

Dated : 22.08.2026  
Place : Bangalore





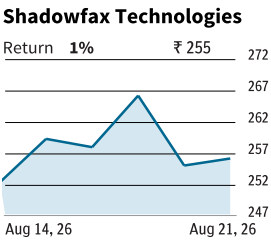




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QUICKLY.

**Qualcomm Ventures sells 1.3% stake in Shadowfax**



**New Delhi:** Global investor Qualcomm Ventures has divested a 1.3 per cent stake in Shadowfax Technologies for ₹184 crore through an open market transaction on Friday. Qualcomm Ventures, through its affiliate Qualcomm Asia Pacific Pte Ltd, offloaded 75 lakh shares at an average price of ₹245.13, taking the deal size to ₹183.85 crore. Qualcomm Ventures is the investment arm of US-based chip major Qualcomm. Following the latest transaction, Qualcomm Ventures' holding in Shadowfax fell to nearly 1 per cent from 2.26 per cent. Details of the buyers of Shadowfax shares could not be ascertained on the exchange. m

**Skyways Air raises ₹174.5 crore from anchors**

**New Delhi:** Skyways Air Services Ltd on Friday raised ₹174.5 crore from anchor investors ahead of its initial public offering (IPO), which opens for subscription on August 24. The company allocated 1.26 crore shares to anchor investors at ₹138 apiece, the upper end of its price band, according to a circular uploaded on the BSE website. Nomura Singapore, Citi Group Global Markets Mauritius, Holani Venture Capital Fund-I, IndusInd General Insurance and ASAS Global Fund were among the investors participating in the anchor round. Additionally, shares were allocated to Bank of India Mutual Fund and Taurus Mutual Fund. m

BROKER'S CALL.

**Emkay Global**

**TVS MOTOR (BUY)**  
Target: ₹5,300  
CMP: ₹4,367.50  
TVS Motor Company's FY26 annual report highlights accelerated execution across 5 strategic priorities — premiumisation, EV leadership, commercial mobility, sustainability, and global expansion — supported by sustained R&D (5x over 10Y to ₹1,250 crore, 2.7 per cent of FY26 revenue) and brand investments (4 per cent of revenue). This has helped TVS Motor become the world's third-largest 2W manufacturer in FY26 (5th in FY21; #2 in FY27T2; #1 in Jul-26), marking what management considers its strongest year on record (sold 5.9 million units). The AR positions premiumisation as the centerpiece, with Norton entering its monetisation phase; its multi-brand portfolio (Jupiter, Apache, Raider, iQube, Ntorq) strengthens positioning across segments. Coupled with the HMLL partnership for next-gen E-3Ws and continued expansion in commercial mobility (including financing tie-ups), these initiatives are expected to drive the next leg of market share gains as the ecosystem matures beyond early scale. The Chairman describes the road ahead as “unpredictable, complex and exciting”, while emphasising TVSL's approach of measured optimism. TVS Motor's ability to anticipate consumer preferences and incubate new share categories should support sustained market share gains, alongside benefits from India's accelerating EV transition. We build in FY26-29E revenue/EBITDA/PAT CAGR of 19/22/26 per cent and reiterate Buy, with an unchanged TP of ₹5,300 at 35x Jun-28E EPS.

**PL Capital**

**NAVIN FLUORINE (ACCUMULATE)**  
Target: ₹8,812  
CMP: ₹8,196.15  
We attended the analyst meet of Navin Fluorine International Ltd (NFLI) and, based on our interaction with the management, the company continue to remain well positioned for a strong multi-year growth trajectory, supported by robust demand across businesses and multiple growth levers. The company's earlier guidance of about 25 per cent revenue CAGR through FY30 remains on track, while R32 capacity expansion and continued CDMO scale-up provide strong near-to-medium-term growth visibility. R32 is expected to contribute around 20-25 per cent of revenue by FY28, with about 30-40 per cent of the expanded capacity already contracted, while the \$100 million CDMO revenue target for FY27 remains on track. In addition, Advanced Materials is emerging as a meaningful long-term growth opportunity, with 19-20 fluorination-based products to contribute 10-15 per cent of revenue by FY30. To support these growth opportunities, the company plans to invest about ₹700 crore in FY27, with annual capex expected at ₹700-1,000 crore over the next 2-3 years across R32, CDMO and Advanced Materials. We expect revenue/EBITDA/PAT to register a CAGR of 22/24/29 per cent over FY26-28E and maintain our ‘Accumulate’ rating on the stock with a target price of ₹8,812, valuing it at 41x FY28E EPS.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: [blmarketwatch@gmail.com](mailto:blmarketwatch@gmail.com)

Brokers, FPIs make merry at the cost of retail

**ZERO-SUM GAME.** 99% of gross profit of FPIs, proprietary traders came from algo; individual investors lost ₹1.70 lakh cr in FY25 & FY26

**Akshata Gorde**  
Mumbai

The cooling down in India's equity derivatives market in FY26 was not just reflected in the fall in retail participation or losses, but also showed up on the profitable side of the trade, where proprietary trading desks largely held on to their gains while foreign portfolio investors (FPIs), mutual funds and corporates saw their profits fall.

Proprietary traders recorded gross trading profits of ₹44,483 crore in FY26, down just 3 per cent from ₹45,955 crore a year earlier, according to the Securities and Exchange Board of India's (SEBI) latest study.

FPIs, by comparison, saw their profits plunge 55 per cent to ₹13,896 crore from ₹31,085 crore in FY25.

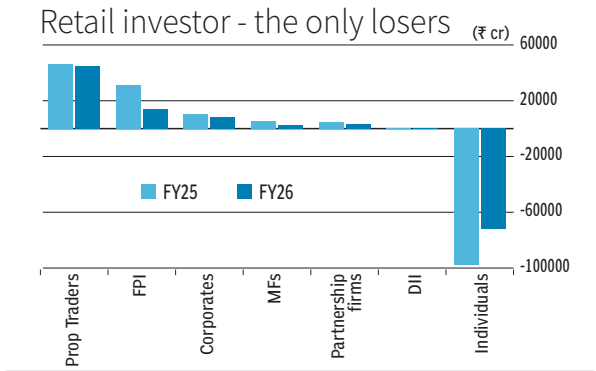
Corporate profits fell 22 per cent to ₹8,092 crore, mutual fund profits dropped 54 per cent to ₹2,595 crore and those of partnership firms and LLPs fell 38 per cent to ₹2,953 crore.

NO LESSON LEARNT

Still individual traders remained the only major category to record an aggregate loss.

Their gross trading loss fell 26 per cent to ₹72,243 crore in FY26 from ₹97,882 crore in FY25, while their net loss after transaction costs stood at ₹91,685 crore, down 18 per cent from the revised ₹1.12 lakh crore in FY25.

Over FY25 and FY26 combined, individual traders incurred gross losses of ₹1,70,125 crore. Proprietary traders earned ₹90,437 crore over the two years, followed by FPIs at ₹44,980 crore, corporates at ₹14,242 crore,



Source: SEBI

mutual funds at ₹8,208 crore and partnership firms and LLPs at ₹7,690 crore.

WHO GAINS THE MOST

SEBI said that derivatives trading is “largely a zero-sum activity before transaction costs”, with individual losses broadly matched by the profits of corporate and institutional participants.

The profitable side, however, is not evenly distributed as the top 10 proprietary entities accounted for ₹33,124 crore, or 74.5 per cent, of the category's ₹44,483 crore gross profit in FY26.

Among FPIs, the top 10 accounted for ₹6,852 crore, or 49.3 per cent, of the category's ₹13,896 crore profit.

Accel, 2 others sell nearly 5% stake in Amagi Media

**Press Trust of India**  
New Delhi

Three entities, including global venture capital firm Accel, on Friday divested nearly a 5 per cent stake in SaaS company Amagi Media Labs for ₹587 crore through open market transactions.

A total of 1,04,88,021 shares were offloaded by Trudy Holdings, AVP I Fund and Accel through its affiliates at an average price of ₹560.

Meanwhile, a clutch of domestic mutual funds, an insurance company and foreign investors participated in the transaction.

Of 432 FPIs, 372 traded through algorithms in FY26, while 323 of 693 proprietary traders did so.

SEBI found that “99 per cent of the gross profit of FPIs and PROP traders came from algo entities”.

ALGO GROWTH

The number of FPI algo entities rose 22 per cent from 306 in FY24 to 372 in FY26, while proprietary algo entities increased 16 per cent to 323. Proprietary traders made ₹43,420 crore of their ₹44,483 crore gross profit from options, while FPIs made ₹10,740 crore.

For individuals, options accounted for ₹66,080 crore of their ₹72,243 crore gross loss.

At the individual level, even the people who made money did better in FY26.

Average profit among profit-makers rose 22 per

cent to ₹1.22 lakh from ₹1 lakh, while the average loss increased 11 per cent to ₹1.47 lakh from ₹1.32 lakh.

Yet losses remained 21 per cent higher than profits on a per-person basis.

“Average losses were higher than average profits in every year during FY22-FY26,” SEBI said.

TRANSACTIONS COST

Transaction costs also continued to weigh more heavily on those who lost: they amounted to 35 percent of gross losses among loss-makers, compared with 21 per cent of gross profits among profit-makers.

Data shows that while the retail loss pool has narrowed, the profitable side remains concentrated among a relatively small group of professional participants, with algorithmic trading playing a dominant role.

Nifty posts 2<sup>nd</sup> straight gain but ends week lower; crude, bond yields cap rally

**Anupama Ghosh**  
Mumbai

The benchmarks closed marginally higher on Friday, extending their recovery for a second consecutive session, even as elevated crude oil prices and rising global bond yields capped gains.

The Sensex added just 3.11 points to settle at 77,540.83, while the Nifty 50 rose 20.15 points to close at 24,252. Despite the two-day pull back from recent lows, the Nifty ended the week 0.47 per cent lower, its second consecutive weekly decline, with the Sensex shedding 0.5 per cent. The session's tone was set

early, with the Nifty opening 53 points higher but spending most of the day locked in a narrow 60-point band, reflecting a lack of directional conviction. Brent crude climbed above \$93 a barrel, on pace for a weekly gain of over 5 per cent, as the US-Iran stand-off intensified.

METAL OUTPERFORM

On the sectoral front, Nifty Metal gained 1 per cent, supported by a rise in LME zinc and broader metal prices. Nifty CPSE also ended in the green. However, Auto, FMCG, IT and Media were among the sharpest decliners for the session.

For the week, FMCG and IT indices lost over 2 per

BSE is eligible exchange in FTSE Russell indices

**Reuters**

FTSE Russell said on Thursday that BSE has met the criteria to be an eligible exchange for its equity indices, paving the way for BSE-listed stocks to be considered for index inclusion and potentially attracting passive fund flows.

Stocks listed on BSE will be assessed for index eligibility from the FTSE's March 2027 review, the index provider said. Any stocks listing on the BSE through IPOs will also be eligible for fast-track screening, it added. If a company is listed on both the BSE and the NSE and passes liquidity tests on both exchanges, the NSE-listed security will be selected for the index as the exchange has more international institutional investor participation, it added. NSE-listed stocks are already eligible for inclusion in FTSE Russell indices.

cent, while the Capital Market index was the top sectoral gainer, rallying 2.55 per cent.

The Nifty Midcap 100 rose 0.10 per cent, while the Nifty Smallcap 100 gained 0.69 per cent.

Hitesh Rath, Technical Analyst - Equity & Derivatives, Angel One, said “Markets continue to exhibit a tentative and cautious stance, with no clear indication of the immediate direction... Against this backdrop, participants should continue to adopt a cautious approach and remain highly selective in their stock-specific approach, focusing on stocks that continue to demonstrate relative strength.”

Atomberg Technologies files DRHP for IPO to raise ₹450 crore

**Our Bureau**  
Bengaluru

Consumer appliances maker Atomberg Technologies has filed its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with SEBI to raise funds through an initial public offering (IPO), as the company looks to expand its brand, research and development (R&D) capabilities and strengthen its balance sheet.

The IPO comprises a fresh issue aggregating to ₹450 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of 7.654 crore shares.

It plans to use ₹90 crore of the net proceeds to repay or prepay certain borrowings, ₹150 crore for brand awareness and performance marketing, and ₹100 crore towards R&D. The remaining will be for general corporate purposes.

PORTFOLIO EXPANSION

Founded by Manoj Meena in 2012, with Sibabrata Das joining as Co-founder in 2013, Atomberg makes consumer appliances, including fans, mixer grinders, water purifiers and cold-pressed



**USE OF FUNDS.** Atomberg Technologies plans to use the IPO proceeds to repay debt, create brand awareness and for research and development purposes

juicers. It also manufactures proprietary components, such as motors and controllers, for enterprise customers, including Voltas, Godrej, and Blue Star, through its subsidiary, Atomberg Innovations.

Atomberg claims the highest market share in India's premium fan segment, defined as fans with an average selling price above ₹3,500, among scaled consumer appliance companies.

According to Redseer, the company had a 46.08 per cent share by cumulative sales value in the premium

fans segment in FY26. The company's revenue rose 34.8 per cent to ₹1,293.77 crore in FY26 from ₹959.51 crore in FY25.

However, adjusted EBITDA declined to ₹37.12 crore from ₹51.35 crore during the same period. Restated loss narrowed to ₹148.88 crore in FY26 from ₹199.08 crore in FY24.

Atomberg has been increasing its presence across online and offline channels.

ICICI Securities, Avendus Capital and IIFL Capital Services are the bankers to the issue.

**Our Bureau**  
Kolkata

Lumino Industries, which will launch its ₹700-crore initial public offering on August 27, has fixed the price band as ₹78-82 a share. The public issue of the Kolkata-based company comprises a fresh issue up to ₹500 crore and an offer for sale up to ₹200 crore by promoters Devendra Goel and Jay Goel.

CAPITAL EXPENDITURE

The proceeds from its fresh issuance worth ₹337 crore will be utilised for prepayment or repayment, in full or in part, of certain outstanding borrowings availed by the company, and around ₹15 crore for capital expenditure for purchase of

PMS industry AUM rises 2% to ₹44.11 lakh cr in July

**Our Bureau**  
Mumbai

The portfolio management services (PMS) industry continued to expand in July, with assets under management (AUM) rising 2 per cent month-on-month to approximately ₹44.11 lakh crore, according to the July 2026 PMS Industry Compendium released by the Association of Portfolio Managers in India (APMI).

The PMS client base grew 1.3 per cent during the month to approximately 2.23 lakh accounts. On a year-on-year basis, both AUM and the client base grew about 11 per cent. Since the start of FY27, AUM has risen 4.3 per cent, while the client base has expanded 5.2 per cent.

DISTRIBUTOR GROWTH

The industry added its highest number of distributors in FY27 so far in July, with 1,226 individual and 181 non-individual distributors joining the ecosystem.

“The PMS industry has reached a scale where its next phase must be defined by greater and wider investor

participation, coupled with greater ease of investing,” APMI Chairman Vikas Khemani said.

The number of SEBI-registered portfolio managers also reached 534, the compendium said.

Capital flows also strengthened, with total PMS net inflows rising to ₹4.66 lakh crore in July from ₹3.55 lakh crore in June. Discretionary services accounted for the bulk of the inflows at ₹4.62 lakh crore, while non-discretionary services recorded net inflows of ₹3,797 crore.

The discretionary segment accounted for 84.7 per cent of total AUM and 95.5 per cent of the client base. Among service categories, co-investment recorded the highest monthly AUM growth at 10.2 per cent, followed by advisory at 3 per cent, non-discretionary at 2.9 per cent and discretionary at 1.8 per cent.

Domestic investors remained accounted for 91 per cent of total AUM. Plain debt remained the largest asset class, accounting for 83 per cent of the PMS book.



Devendra Goel, MD, Lumino Industries

equipment and machinery, civil works and interior development of an existing manufacturing facility, and general corporate purposes.

The company informed that its new facility in West Bengal is expected to come in the second half of the current fiscal.

This new facility will help the company expand its product range.

“We have two verticals. One is the product, and the other is the EPC. In product, we manufacture cables, which are used for power centres. We manufacture conductors, which again is used for power centres. The other vertical is EPC. Around 70 per cent of the revenue comes from the product, and 30 per cent of the revenue comes from the EPC. The product that we manufacture is also used in our EPC. So there is a unique integration between the product that we manufacture and the EPCs that we do,” said Devendra Goel, MD, Lumino Industries.

Currently, the company has two manufacturing plants in Kolkata, with an overall installed capacity of 40,000 tonnes annually.

Nifty 50 Movers

|                             | Close(%) | Pts   | PE     | WN(%) |
|-----------------------------|----------|-------|--------|-------|
| ICICI Bank                  | 1420.00  | 12.68 | 17.05  | 9.17  |
| Kotak Bank                  | 402.80   | 8.77  | 19.74  | 2.67  |
| PowerGrid Corp              | 272.40   | 7.52  | 15.94  | 1.11  |
| HDFC Bank                   | 726.95   | 6.36  | 13.57  | 10.03 |
| Reliance Ind                | 1316.00  | 4.13  | 20.20  | 8.01  |
| Bharat Elec                 | 414.00   | 3.60  | 49.23  | 1.34  |
| L&T                         | 4093.00  | 3.07  | 28.69  | 4.34  |
| HDFC Life                   | 554.80   | 3.01  | 60.61  | 0.54  |
| NestleIndia                 | 1477.10  | 2.99  | 74.74  | 0.95  |
| Bharti Airtel               | 1946.00  | 2.86  | 32.56  | 5.33  |
| NTPC                        | 340.00   | 2.59  | 11.64  | 1.45  |
| Bajaj Finserv               | 2032.50  | 2.09  | 15.76  | 1.06  |
| Titan                       | 5066.10  | 1.63  | 78.39  | 1.89  |
| Asian Paints                | 2640.00  | 1.46  | 52.35  | 1.08  |
| Coal India                  | 405.20   | 1.41  | 8.01   | 0.87  |
| Hindalco                    | 1034.00  | 1.31  | 14.17  | 1.35  |
| SBI Life                    | 1792.90  | 1.07  | 69.15  | 0.73  |
| ITCS                        | 2302.00  | 0.89  | 16.64  | 2.12  |
| Grasim Ind                  | 3308.00  | 0.66  | 19.78  | 1.12  |
| Adani Ports                 | 1700.00  | 0.64  | 29.85  | 1.13  |
| State Bank                  | 1048.70  | 0.63  | 10.80  | 3.91  |
| Shriram Finance Ltd.        | 1130.00  | 0.55  | 23.49  | 1.43  |
| Max Healthcare              | 1000.00  | 0.34  | 66.78  | 0.67  |
| Adani Enter                 | 2997.00  | 0.13  | 51.90  | 0.78  |
| EssarLtd                    | 226.00   | 0.08  | 731.02 | 2.14  |
| Bajaj Finance               | 1095.00  | 0.00  | 33.02  | 2.64  |
| Wipro                       | 180.79   | -0.12 | 13.48  | 0.44  |
| UltraTech Cement            | 11570.00 | -0.13 | 39.78  | 1.23  |
| Sun Pharma                  | 1902.40  | -0.37 | 37.67  | 1.82  |
| Jio Financial Services Ltd. | 244.00   | -0.43 | 77.97  | 0.72  |
| Cipla                       | 1432.20  | -0.71 | 34.48  | 0.73  |
| Dr Reddy's Lab              | 1174.70  | -0.71 | 30.80  | 0.65  |
| Tata Steel                  | 183.00   | -0.90 | 20.28  | 1.36  |
| Apollo Hosp                 | 8693.00  | -0.94 | 57.55  | 0.81  |
| Eicher Motors               | 8010.00  | -0.96 | 38.09  | 0.99  |
| TataConsumerProduct         | 1049.00  | -1.04 | 63.21  | 0.62  |
| Tata Motors PV              | 317.90   | -1.07 | 0.00   | 0.60  |
| Tech Mahindra               | 1584.00  | -1.32 | 30.03  | 0.91  |
| JSW Steel                   | 1293.70  | -1.23 | 11.30  | 1.09  |
| ONGC                        | 236.40   | -1.78 | 6.64   | 0.83  |
| Bajaj Auto                  | 11700.00 | -2.25 | 28.31  | 1.17  |
| M&M                         | 3412.20  | -2.46 | 20.96  | 2.74  |
| Hind Unilever               | 2015.00  | -2.52 | 45.12  | 1.61  |
| Int'lGrubbeInd              | 5110.00  | -2.72 | 6.00   | 1.04  |
| Airtel Bank                 | 12345.00 | -3.45 | 13.87  | 3.22  |
| Trent Ltd.                  | 2924.00  | -3.34 | 85.92  | 0.88  |
| HCL Tech                    | 1302.50  | -3.66 | 20.27  | 1.24  |
| ITC                         | 269.40   | -4.74 | 16.72  | 2.34  |
| Infosys                     | 1121.00  | -6.90 | 15.00  | 3.54  |
| Maruti Suzuki               | 13565.00 | -6.96 | 29.75  | 1.59  |

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

|                             | Close(%) | Pts    | PE     | WN(%) |
|-----------------------------|----------|--------|--------|-------|
| anta                        | 279.00   | 54.21  | 6.53   | 1.86  |
| Hindus Zinc                 | 594.90   | 29.35  | 14.73  | 1.12  |
| Adani Power                 | 205.50   | 18.09  | 27.27  | 3.35  |
| AdaniGreenEnergy            | 1230.00  | 17.73  | 101.32 | 1.74  |
| MuthootFin                  | 3022.00  | 16.21  | 10.59  | 1.27  |
| Bpcl                        | 311.00   | 13.55  | 7.88   | 2.48  |
| Bank Of Baroda              | 247.00   | 13.48  | 6.94   | 1.80  |
| United Spirits              | 1556.00  | 10.30  | 67.09  | 1.81  |
| Siemens                     | 3920.00  | 10.28  | 96.09  | 1.36  |
| Div's Lab                   | 8597.00  | 9.97   | 78.03  | 4.26  |
| Solar Industries            | 19900.00 | 9.91   | 87.82  | 1.90  |
| Jindal Steel                | 1127.80  | 9.58   | 42.47  | 1.64  |
| ZydusLifesciences           | 1120.00  | 8.94   | 24.54  | 1.10  |
| Ambuja Cements              | 414.50   | 6.34   | 19.86  | 1.01  |
| DIF                         | 678.10   | 3.64   | 37.75  | 1.71  |
| Canara Bank                 | 129.96   | 3.52   | 5.95   | 1.72  |
| MacroTech Developers        | 1242.00  | 1.61   | 30.05  | 1.35  |
| HindustanAeronautics        | 5000.00  | 1.10   | 35.87  | 3.73  |
| Siemens Energy India        | 3435.60  | 0.08   | 82.22  | 1.19  |
| Indian OilCorp              | 135.90   | 0.00   | 5.37   | 1.99  |
| Tvs Motor Cmp               | 4390.00  | -0.00  | 57.92  | 4.05  |
| Indian Railway Finance Corp | 86.40    | -0.41  | 15.70  | 0.68  |
| Shree Cement                | 24280.00 | -0.78  | 53.54  | 1.28  |
| Tata Capital                | 365.05   | -1.61  | 28.29  | 0.72  |
| SamvardnathersonInternat    | 169.38   | -2.57  | 39.25  | 2.94  |
| Power Finance               | 363.00   | -3.39  | 3.56   | 2.08  |
| Hyundai Motor India         | 2218.80  | -3.40  | 36.41  | 1.24  |
| Gail (India)                | 172.00   | -3.92  | 11.46  | 1.82  |
| Maazgan Dock                | 2552.00  | -3.97  | 36.07  | 0.76  |
| Tata Power                  | 374.30   | -4.60  | 22.75  | 2.46  |
| Rural Elec                  | 326.65   | -5.26  | 5.36   | 1.60  |
| Bajaj Holdings              | 11320.00 | -6.04  | 14.01  | 1.92  |
| Adani Energy Solutions      | 1541.90  | -6.30  | 59.94  | 1.99  |
| Siemens Bank                | 1834.5   | -6.91  | 6.78   | 1.39  |
| Shree Cmc                   | 2610.00  | -8.29  | 37.96  | 2.09  |
| India                       | 7424.0   | -8.39  | 101.16 | 1.53  |
| litind                      | 1645.00  | -9.91  | 6.01   | 1.60  |
| ch                          | 48200.00 | -13.86 | 66.16  | 2.01  |
| Bank Natl Bank              | 116.55   | -14.51 | 62.75  | 1.58  |
| an Hotels Co.               | 730.00   | -14.93 | 45.01  | 2.52  |
| Irej Consumer               | 930.00   | -16.35 | 49.89  | 1.47  |
| hindtree                    | 4487.80  | -17.60 | 25.62  | 1.64  |
| Power & Ind Sol             | 867.00   | -18.53 | 110.29 | 2.33  |
| ntuseuper                   | 3906.00  | -25.29 | 83.32  | 2.47  |
| nt                          | 472.55   | -30.65 | 41.56  | 1.88  |
| an Beverages                | 430.10   | -32.58 | 42.67  | 2.31  |
| hammadalamin&f              | 1862.90  | -32.69 | 27.61  | 3.17  |
| naminds India               | 5107.50  | -38.27 | 59.81  | 2.71  |
| renter Pharma               | 4896.50  | -46.25 | 86.39  | 2.82  |
| anna Ind                    | 5365.00  | -62.64 | 49.51  | 2.48  |



Resource guzzlers

Data centres should account for water, power demand

Protests over data-centre projects in Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh are a warning India should not ignore. Activists and citizens have taken to the streets over concerns that these projects will add to the strain on local water and energy supplies. Data-centre operators say advanced air-cooling technology will minimise impact on water resources, but there is no transparency on the cumulative demand these facilities will place on water, electricity and other infrastructure.

Data centres are not new to India. What is changing is their scale and intensity. Installed capacity has grown from about 520 MW in 2020 to nearly 1.5 GW by mid-2025, and is set to rise sharply over the next few years. Much of this capacity is concentrated in Mumbai, Chennai, Hyderabad and Bengaluru — cities where power and water infrastructure are already under considerable strain. High-density AI servers consume far more electricity and generate more heat than conventional servers, demanding sophisticated cooling. India’s data-centre water consumption is estimated at about 150 billion litres a year, and could rise to nearly 358 billion litres by 2030. A single 100-MW facility has been estimated to need around two million litres of water a day — though actual use varies widely with cooling technology and water source. The industry’s response is that technology is improving fast. Operators are adopting advanced cooling systems, and some are designing facilities that use little or no water at all. That is welcome, but efficiency cannot be the whole answer: a facility that is more efficient per unit of computing can still carry a large resource footprint. This is because the scale of computing is set to expand quickly, raising the demand for reliable power. The latest wave of expansion is turning into a race for electricity and cooling infrastructure.

India needs centralised guardrails and greater transparency. At present, decisions on land, water, power, environmental clearances and local infrastructure are scattered across multiple Central, State and local authorities, making it hard to assess the cumulative impact of a cluster of data centres. Citizens have no easy way to find out how much water a facility has been allocated, where that water comes from, how much power it will draw, or what additional infrastructure it will require. A national mechanism should require large data-centre projects to publicly disclose projected electricity and water consumption, source of water, cooling technology, renewable-energy use, wastewater arrangements and impact on local infrastructure — aggregated by district and State, so policymakers and citizens can see the cumulative burden. It may also be time to revive the National Data Centre Policy, whose 2020 draft proposed Data Centre Economic Zones — specialised clusters with planned infrastructure spanning power, connectivity and regulation. The goal is not to stop the data-centre boom, but to make resource costs visible and measurable.

OTHER VOICES.

讀賣新聞  
THE YOMIURI SHIMBUN

**Concerns about Reduced Deterrence against N. Korea**  
While North Korea rapidly enhances its combat capabilities and China continues its military intimidation, the U.S. and South Korean militaries have significantly scaled back their joint military exercises. There are concerns that this could lead to a reduction in deterrence against North Korea and China, among others, and negatively impact stability throughout Northeast Asia, including Japan. The United States and South Korea had initially planned to conduct their regular joint military exercises this summer from Aug. 17 to 27, but they shortened the duration to five days ending Aug. 21. This was because U.S. President Donald Trump instructed Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth to scale back the exercises just before they were set to begin. Trump argued that the exercises “send a signal that is totally inappropriate and hostile” to North Korea. TOKYO, AUGUST 21

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.  
EUROPE

**The Supreme Court’s Popular Mandate**  
Rep. Hakeem Jeffries, the betting favorite for Speaker of the House next year, said last week that he wants “dramatic Supreme Court reform,” because the conservative majority is “basically a subsidiary” of President Trump’s MAGA project. Did Mr. Jeffries sleep through the Court’s last term? Even liberal Justice Elena Kagan has publicly corrected his mistaken impression. The Justices have struck down Mr. Trump’s signature initiatives on tariffs, birthright citizenship, and the Federal Reserve. What’s more, the public by and large approves of last term’s major decisions, according to a poll this month from Marquette Law School. To the conservative Justices, public opinion is beside the point, since they see their job as following the law, not the vox populi. But consider the weakness of Mr. Jeffries’s case. NEW YORK, AUGUST 20

Tribunal reform  
2026: Old wine  
in a new bottle

**COSMETIC CHANGE.** The 2026 Bill adds an NTC, extends tenure and removes the minimum age, but leaves the basic architecture of the 2021 law largely intact



RAJASEKHAR VK

The Tribunals Reforms Bill, 2026, is presented as the next chapter in India’s effort to reform its tribunal system. It promises a National Tribunals Commission (NTC), greater institutional oversight and a more coherent framework for appointments and service conditions. But there is a more fundamental question to be asked before the Bill is celebrated as a new phase of reform: how much of it is actually new? The answer is: surprisingly little. The 2026 Bill retains the same 16 tribunals in its First Schedule. It retains the basic legislative approach of prescribing common qualifications, selection, appointment and conditions of service for those tribunals. But the Central government remains an important part of the appointment architecture. The material changes? The proposed NTC, an increase in tenure from four years to five, and the removal of the minimum age of 50 years. The five-year tenure and removal of the minimum age address two features of the 2021 framework that had attracted serious Constitutional criticism. But they do not, by themselves, constitute a fundamental reconstruction of the tribunal system. The more accurate description would be that the 2026 Bill is a revised edition of the 2021 model, with some important repairs and a new institutional layer in the form of the NTC. The bottle, therefore, may be old, but the label is new. The real question is whether the cork has changed — whether the appointment mechanism will actually function differently, and whether it will alter the balance between the Executive and the tribunals.

**WHAT CHANGED IN 2021?**  
The 2021 Act was itself the second stage of a longer process of tribunal

rationalisation that began with the Finance Act, 2017, through which several tribunals were abolished or merged and their number reduced. The 2021 legislation moved the needle further, abolishing five more tribunals. For the tribunals that remained, it sought to create a uniform statutory framework for qualifications, selection, appointment, tenure, salaries and allowances, resignation, removal and other conditions of service. The 2021 Act’s fatal flaw was its bureaucratic hubris, the assumption that a one-size-fits-all statutory regime could displace the Constitution’s demand for independent adjudicatory institutions. In Madras Bar Association v. Union of India, the Supreme Court struck down provisions of the 2021 framework on grounds including separation of powers and judicial independence. The 2026 Bill is, therefore, in part, a response to that judicial intervention. Its Statement of Objects and Reasons expressly acknowledges the Supreme Court judgment and the direction concerning a National Tribunals Commission. But that raises the central question: has the government redesigned the tribunal system, or has it merely excised portions of the 2021 framework that did not survive constitutional scrutiny? **WHAT IS NEW IN 2026?** The changes introduced by the 2026 Bill are important, but limited. The most visible innovation is the creation of the NTC, proposed as the institutional body responsible for the selection process for tribunal members, review of tribunal **NCLAT is included in the First Schedule. NCLT is not. The omission is difficult to reconcile with the stated objective of creating a coherent and uniform framework for tribunal governance**

performance, oversight of inquiries into complaints and maintenance of a National Tribunals Data Grid. The change in tenure from four years to five years is also welcome, as is the removal of the minimum age requirement. Search-cum-Selection Committees remain part of the appointment mechanism, albeit within the new NTC structure. These changes respond directly to some of the difficulties that had arisen under the 2021 framework. But beyond them, the basic architecture remains the same, with the same 16 tribunals covered. The real test lies in the appointment mechanism. The NTC’s creation should not, by itself, be mistaken for a complete restructuring of tribunal governance. The Central government continues to have a significant role. What happens if the government does not appoint the candidate recommended by the NTC? Or if it sits on the recommendation? Or simply seeks a fresh list? The answer to these questions will determine whether the NTC has actually altered the balance between the Executive and the tribunals, or has merely inserted another institutional layer into an essentially familiar framework. **THE NCLT OMISSION** There is, however, one feature of the 2026 Bill that is difficult to explain. An institutional schizophrenia, so to speak. NCLAT is included in the First Schedule. NCLT is not. The 2026 Bill simply carries that position forward from the 2021 Act, without explaining why. The omission is difficult to reconcile with the stated objective of creating a coherent and uniform framework for tribunal governance. NCLT is the Adjudicating Authority under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code and exercises substantial jurisdiction under the Companies Act. NCLAT is its appellate tribunal. Yet, the Bill proposes to bring the appointment and service conditions of NCLAT within the new regime while leaving NCLT outside it. The inconsistency becomes more striking because the 2026 Bill expressly

amends section 417A of the Companies Act to provide that the qualifications, selections, appointment, salaries, removal and other conditions of service of the Chairperson and Members of NCLAT will be governed by the new legislation. There is no corresponding provision bringing NCLT within the framework. Notably, the Statement of Objects and Reasons does not even explain the exclusion. If the omission in the 2021 framework was inadvertent, reproducing it in a Bill intended to repeal and replace the framework is difficult to justify. A legislation intended to create uniformity in tribunal governance should not reproduce an unexplained distinction between a tribunal and its appellate tribunal. The government should therefore explain why NCLT has once again been left outside the reform framework and, if there is no substantive reason, correct the omission before the Bill becomes law. **REFORM OR REPAIR?** The Tribunals Reforms Bill, 2026, is therefore best understood as a measure of correction rather than a fundamental redesign. It increases tenure, removes the minimum age and introduces the National Tribunals Commission. Those are meaningful changes. But the basic architecture remains largely intact. The same tribunal universe remains, the Executive continues to occupy an important position in the appointment structure, and an unexplained omission from the 2021 framework has been carried into the 2026 Bill. Tribunal reform should ultimately be judged by whether it produces institutions that can tell the government, ‘No’. On that test, the 2026 Bill may be a step forward. But whether it is genuinely a new bottle will depend on whether Parliament is prepared to address the structural questions that the 2021 experiment left unresolved. The writer is a lawyer and former Judicial Member of the National Company Law Tribunal

Nabard survey points to downbeat rural sentiment

Subdued optimism over jobs and income seems linked to monsoon, rural inflation and broader economic developments

A Paul Williams  
M Nagarajan

The twelfth round of the Rural Economic Conditions and Sentiments Survey (RECSS), released by the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) in July, offers the clearest signal yet that the rural growth story is losing some of its earlier momentum. Since the survey began in September 2024, each round has tracked how villages across the country feel about their incomes, spending, savings and borrowing. The latest findings show that optimism has cooled, consumption has softened and households are leaning more heavily on informal credit to bridge the gap. Only 27.7 per cent of rural households reported earning more than they did a year earlier, down from 29.6 per cent in the previous round and sharply lower than the 42.2 per cent recorded in November 2025. This is the lowest reading since the survey started, and it is matched by a rise in the share of households whose income simply did not move, which climbed to 52.6 per cent, the highest such share recorded so far. NABARD linked the moderation to a mix of

pressures, including former global commodity prices, worries around El Nino conditions, below normal rainfall in several regions and a slower pace of kharif sowing. Even so, the report was careful to note that rural conditions have stayed broadly stable, helped along by the steady progress of the southwest monsoon and continued public spending in villages. The share of households reporting higher consumption expenditure fell to 74.1 per cent, only the second time this figure has slipped below 75 per cent since the survey began. Household consumption still accounts for roughly two thirds of monthly income. On the financial side, the proportion of households reporting higher savings dropped to 17.8 per cent, the weakest reading since the survey’s launch, while the share reporting higher borrowings eased to 28.7 per cent. **RISE IN INFORMAL CREDIT** Even as overall borrowing has moderated, the share of households relying exclusively on informal sources of credit rose to 23.6 per cent, the highest level recorded across all rounds of the survey, while 51 per cent depended only on formal channels. Among those who borrowed purely through informal routes, close to two-thirds turned to friends and



RURAL INDIA. Need for support

relatives rather than moneylenders or other informal agents. The survey also captured a more cautious rural mood about the months ahead. Expectations for income and employment improving over the next quarter fell to their lowest level since the survey began, and expectations for income over the coming year weakened further as well. Nabard attributed part of this caution to uncertainty around the monsoon and to broader economic developments. These findings arrive alongside separate data showing that rural inflation touched 5 per cent in June, a full percentage point above urban inflation at 4 per cent. The combination of slowing income growth and comparatively higher inflation helps explain why rural sentiment has turned more guarded.

**WAY FORWARD** Timely and adequate monsoon support measures, including crop advisories, seed and input availability, and quick disbursement of crop insurance claims, can help protect farm incomes from the swings of El Nino related uncertainty. Second, the rising reliance on informal credit points to a continuing need to widen the reach of formal finance in villages, whether through self-help groups, cooperative banks or digital lending platforms designed for rural borrowers. Third, given that food price pressure weighs more heavily on rural households, sustained attention to supply side measures for essential commodities, along with continuity in existing income support and employment guarantee schemes, would help. Finally, since the survey itself shows how quickly rural sentiment can shift from round to round, policymakers, banks and agricultural agencies would do well to treat each successive round of the Rural Economic Conditions and Sentiments Survey as an early warning system. Williams is the Head of India at Sernova Financial; Nagarajan is an Assistant Professor in Management Studies at SRMIST Trichy

● **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to [bleditor@thehindu.co.in](mailto:bleditor@thehindu.co.in) or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

**Unfair move**  
Apropos ‘SBI widens cash withdrawal charges to all basic accounts’ to plug fee income leak (August 21). It is shocking that the SBI has announced uniform levy service charges for withdrawals exceeding four, whether drawn through branch or through Customer service points etc. Not all customers are tech savvy and even ones having an ATM card are forced to go to bank branches for cash withdrawals. Given that deposits are not keeping pace with lending, charging customers

for branch visits is unfair. Since banks have various other avenues to earn revenues, why charge savers who form the backbone of the banking system? **Katuru Durga Prasad Rao** Hyderabad **E-comm growth** This is with reference to ‘Home care start-ups take on FMCG giants as consumer priorities shift’, (August 21). FMCG household consumption across Indian cities exhibited a clear shift toward metro-driven concentration

rather than uniform city-wise distribution, with e-commerce accounting for approximately 14 per cent of FMCG sales across metros and increasing to nearly 18 per cent in the top eight cities. Notably, southern metro clusters have emerged as the most digitally savvy consumption hubs, crossing 21 per cent e-commerce penetration, underscoring a strong shift toward online-led household purchasing behaviour, even as overall urban FMCG growth remained relatively moderate in the range of 2.3-4.6 per

cent, reflecting a structurally uneven but increasingly digital-first consumption landscape across India’s cities. The opportunity is only getting bigger. **S Muthulakshmi** Virudhunagar (TN) **Refined regulation** This refers to the Editorial ‘Know your investor’ (August 8). SEBI’s effort to simplify the Accredited Investor Framework is commendable, but caution is vital. Allowing investment funds to certify their own investors





QUICKLY.  
2 more insurers barred  
from opening new offices



**Hyderabad:** The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has barred Edelweiss Life Insurance and Pramerica Life Insurance from opening any new offices for six months as they violated norms pertaining to the permissible expenses of management (EoM) limits. The action followed off-site monitoring, examination of submissions made by the insurers and subsequent enforcement proceedings. IRDAI said the prescribed limits are intended to ensure that insurers follow prudent cost norms and manage expenses efficiently, so that the benefits of operational efficiencies are ultimately passed on to policyholders. **OUR BUREAU**

# PFRDA sets ambitious target of 5 cr non-govt NPS users vs 90 lakh now

**DIGITAL OUTREACH.** The growth is expected to be driven by new digital onboarding partnerships

**Sindhu Hariharan**  
Chennai

The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) has set itself an ambitious target of taking the non-government NPS subscriber base to 5 crore this financial year, up sharply from around 90 lakh currently.

This growth is expected to be driven by new digital onboarding partnerships, such as the Tatkal NPS built with NPCI and the STAR NPS built in partnership with BSE.

“These two new platforms [Tatkal NPS and STAR NPS] are, in a way, out, and a few banks have initially started testing it. It’s in what we call a live testing phase,” PFRDA Chairperson Sivasub-

ramanian Ramann said on Friday.

“Four big banks are currently testing it and reporting bugs, and we have 22 banks, who are integrating with the system, and in the next 45 days, all these banks should be ready too,” he said.

He was speaking to select mediapersons on the sidelines of an outreach programme in the city.

**AUM GROWTH**

While STAR NPS is a fully-digital assisted-onboarding platform developed by BSE Technologies Pvt Ltd, allowing pension agents (including mutual fund distributors) to execute paperless KYC verifications and swift registrations, Tatkal NPS, built with NPCI, leverages the latter’s platform to allow customers rapid, secure KYC

“We have now created the NPS Bharat Fund of Funds. We will be giving money to various AIFs and will become limited partners through this

**SIVASUBRAMANIAN RAMANN**  
PFRDA Chairperson



verification and instant generation of a Permanent Retirement Account Number (PRAN).

“PhonePe alone has around 65 crore customers and is getting ready to operate on Tatkal NPS by the end of August, potentially giving us access to a huge pool of customers who can now ex-

perience seamless onboarding,” Ramann added.

The Chairman declined to estimate an AUM growth for the fiscal, and said that they are hoping for a 22 per cent growth in contributions. Current NPS AUM stands at about ₹18.4 lakh crore.

Non-government NPS accounts have risen from about

72 lakh in October last year to 90 lakh currently, representing roughly 25 per cent growth.

Interestingly, we may soon see the first NPS investment into an alternative investment fund (AIF).

Ramann said the PFRDA is expanding the asset classes available to NPS, with particular emphasis on REITs, InvITs and AIFs, and has allowed up to 5 per cent of the equity portfolio of non-government NPS funds to be allocated to AIFs, compared with up to 1 per cent for government funds.

“We have now created the NPS Bharat Fund of Funds. We will be giving money to various AIFs and will become limited partners through this. The board of the PFRDA approved the concept of investing in AIFs 5 years ago.”

## RBI meeting at Chennai reviews current economic situation, global challenges

**Our Bureau**  
Chennai



Sanjay Malhotra, Governor, Reserve Bank of India

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) held the 624<sup>th</sup> meeting of its Central Board of Directors in Chennai on Friday.

The event was held under the Chairmanship of Sanjay Malhotra, Governor of the RBI.

As per a statement issued by the Reserve Bank, the board, in its meeting, reviewed the current economic situation and global and domestic challenges, including risks to the economic outlook.

“The board also reviewed the various areas of operations of the Reserve Bank, including the functioning of its committees and the ombudsman scheme,” it added.

hit Jain and other Directors of the Central Board, including Revathy Iyer, Prof Sachin Chaturvedi, industrialist Anand Mahindra and former ISRO Chairman Somanath Sreedhara Panicker attended the meeting.

Earlier in the day, Malhotra also called on Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay at the Secretariat, accompanied by a small team of RBI officials.

**MEETING ATTENDEES**

Deputy Governors Swaminathan J, Dr Poonam Gupta, Shirish Chandra Murmu, Ro-

## Vembu Technologies looks at ₹500 cr revenue in India within five years

**Rohan Das**  
Chennai



Sekar Vembu, CEO, Vembu Technologies

Vembu Technologies, a Chennai-based company specialising in data backup and disaster recovery solutions, is expecting to grow its business in India to around ₹500 crore in the next five years, making it among the top three such companies in the country.

The company is looking to deepen its presence in the India market at a time when the government’s Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) regulations have made reliable backup and recovery solutions critical for Indian businesses.

ness is fairly small, without sharing the absolute value.

Vembu was part of the founding team of Zoho (launched as AdventNet in the 1990s) and eventually left the company to pursue his own entrepreneurial ventures. Globally, North America is Vembu Technology’s largest market, with a topline contribution of 50 per cent, followed by Europe with 20 per cent and the remaining spread across West Asia,

South America and other parts of the world. India currently contributes roughly 2-5 per cent.

**INDIA FOCUSED**

“Earlier, most of our sales came from abroad. But, in the last one year, we have been focusing more on India. With the DPDP coming in, compliance has become a big thing and companies that were earlier not taking backup seriously now have to,” he said.

To expand its businesses in India, Vembu said there is a need to invest roughly ₹100 crore in the next 3-5 years to ramp up pre-sales, partner acquisition and marketing efforts. Vembu added that even globally the company is trying to build channels.

“We are slowly transitioning into a 100 per cent channel company and reducing reliance on online sales,” he

said. Vembu Technologies is also looking upmarket, both globally and in India, with the intention for a larger share of its customer mix to be mid-market to enterprise clients.

“AI is making software development very easy. We don’t know how it will go in backup and recovery, but in a lot of workflow software SMBs will have a lot more cheap options. The software will essentially be commoditised, and you cannot make money out of SMBs. So the money then is in the bigger enterprise clients, where there is much more domain expertise needed and depth,” he said.

Meanwhile, industry estimates peg the enterprise-grade backup and disaster recovery solutions sector at around ₹5,000-9,000 crore, growing at 15-20 per cent per year.

## DRDO signs two defence tech transfer agreements

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

The Defence Research and Development Organisation’s (DRDO) Naval Science and Technological Laboratory (NSTL) has signed two licensing agreements for the transfer of technology with a state-owned company and a private firm, strengthening indigenous defence manufacturing capabilities.

submarine fired decoy (SFD) Mohini, which is an underwater countermeasure system launched from a submarine’s decoy launch tubes or torpedo tubes to protect the vessel against incoming

acoustic-homing torpedoes.

The DRDO lab also transferred technology for the fabrication, installation and commissioning of the LM2500 gas turbine to VerTex Engineering Systems

Private Ltd, Hyderabad, which manufactures high-pressure components from specialised metals and speciality stainless steels for warship, aircraft carrier and missile applications.

**TRAVANCORE TITANIUM PRODUCTS LIMITED**  
Thiruvananthapuram - 21  
Email id : project@ttpltd.in

**E-TENDER NOTICE**  
E-tenders are invited for the following works in TTPL. Tenders can be submitted only by online through the portal [www.etenders.kerala.gov.in](http://www.etenders.kerala.gov.in)  
Name of Work : 1  
Design, Engineering, Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Air Motoriser with a capacity of 2-120Kg/hr for Lithium Titanate.  
Tender ID: 2026 TTPL 865015 1  
Due date: 15.09.2026  
Name of Work : 2  
Design, Engineering, Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Wet grinder (Edge Runner mill) with a capacity of 500 litre for grinding of Lithium Titanate.  
Tender ID: 2026 TTPL 863197 1  
Due date: 11.09.2026  
For more details & tenders please visit our website [www.travancoretitanium.com](http://www.travancoretitanium.com)  
Sd/-  
Dy. General Manager (Proj)

**TATA POWER**  
The Tata Power Company Limited  
(Mundra Thermal Power Station - UMPP)  
Tunda Vandi Road, Tunda Village, Mundra, Kutch, Gujarat  
Reg. Office: Bombay House, 24 Homi Modi Street, Mumbai - 400 001

**NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST**  
The Tata Power Company Limited hereby invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from eligible bidders for the following requirement for 4150 MW UMPP Mundra Thermal Power Station (MTPS):  
1. Procurement of MS Pipes & Bends with Cast Basalt Lining at Tata Power, Mundra (Ref. 4100070024)  
2. Replacement of Fire Doors and Rolling Shutters at Plant area (Ref no: 4100070025).  
For prequalification requirements, tender fee, bid security etc., please visit Tender section of our website (**URL: <https://www.tatapower.com/tender/tenders-listing>**) and refer detailed Tender Notice for subject tender. Eligible bidders willing to participate in this tender may submit their Expression of Interest along with the Tender Fee latest by 31/08/2026

## Preference for comprehensive health cover growing: HDFC ERGO General Insurance MD & CEO

bl.interview

**G Naga Sridhar**  
Hyderabad

“The regulatory changes over the last four years have been extremely pro-customer, aimed at improving awareness, affordability and accessibility



**PARTHANIL GHOSH**  
MD & CEO,  
HDFC ERGO General Insurance

Recent insurance reforms are giving a fresh push to customer demand while strengthening transparency and affordability, says HDFC ERGO General Insurance MD and CEO Parthanil Ghosh, who expects the changes to support wider insurance penetration. The general insurance player has also been investing heavily in technology in its operations.

*Edited excerpts:*

**How do you see the impact of the recent insurance reforms on the industry, businesses and customers?**

The regulatory changes over the last four years have been extremely pro-customer, aimed at improving awareness, affordability and accessibility. The GST reforms address affordability, while the Insurance Act amendments and regulations seek greater accountability and transparency from insurers.

This is important because the trust quotient between consumers and insurers needs to improve. Around 9 per cent of people get some kind of claim in a year across products, while the remaining 91 per cent need confidence that their insurer will support them when an insured event occurs. Greater transparency can help build that confidence.

**What impact are these reforms having on HDFC ERGO’s business?**

We have seen strong customer traction. From Octo-

ber 1, our new retail health insurance business has been growing by more than 100 per cent compared with the same month of the previous year. Overall retail health, including renewals, grew around 52 per cent in the last three months, while motor insurance premium grew 55 per cent.

Our first-quarter overall growth was 20.6 per cent, about twice the industry growth. Our health claims payout ratio in the first quarter was 98.3 per cent. The commercial lines market is currently in a very soft cycle, but we have focused on protecting our portfolio and balance sheet and reducing volatility.

**What are the key trends you see in health insurance and customer preferences?**

Consumers are increasingly looking for comprehensive health covers without having to worry about what is payable or not payable at hospitals. They are also concerned about medical inflation and whether their sum insured will be adequate. Our Optima Secure Plus has consumables cover built in and increases the base sum insured every year irrespective

of claims. A ₹10 lakh policy can become a ₹1 crore policy after 10 years under the product’s structure. We have also provided a 5 per cent lifelong discount on the prevailing premium for customers who join before age 35.

Consumers are also seeking cashless services, OPD benefits and wellness covers.

**Is ‘insurance for all by 2047’ achievable?**

I am very confident that India will become a developed country by 2047, and insurance for all has to happen by then or preferably before that. The structural reforms are moving in the right direction. The industry is working on creative, affordable products and solutions that can reach customers digitally or physically.

The challenge is to reach the missing middle and improve affordability and last-mile access through platforms such as Bima Sugam and government schemes. Parametric insurance also offers an opportunity, particularly because only 10-15 per cent of economic losses from natural catastrophes are estimated to be covered by insurance.

**How are you investing**

**in technology? Now there is AI everywhere. How are you deploying it?**

We have been investing for a long time in building a very strong core system. At the same time, we are developing platforms where Gen Z customers feel comfortable interacting with us. Our website and online portal receive a large volume of traffic — around 4 to 4.5 crore visits every year.

We have also introduced a ‘quiet mode’ option on the portal. Normally, if you leave your phone number, someone from the company may contact you. But if you select ‘quiet mode’, no one from the company will call or disturb you. It is entirely up to the customer.

**What could be the impact of permission for 100 per cent FDI? What about your company and capital infusion plans?**

Our shareholders are all strong players in terms of distribution and reach and also from a capital perspective. Each brings its own strengths to the partnership.

Munich Re and ERGO bring deep technical expertise in insurance, while HDFC brings a strong presence in India, a trusted household name and significant brand value. I think this creates a great, and indeed unparalleled, synergy in the Indian insurance space. Both our shareholders are also capitalised well, so we have no issues with access to capital to support our growth.

That said, our capital requirements are relatively limited, as we are able to fund our growth largely through our own balance sheet.

### Enterprise Connect

#### HDFC Bank Urges Citizens to Stay Vigilant Against ‘Boss Scam’

HDFC Bank, India’s leading private sector bank, advises customers to remain vigilant against Boss Scam (impersonation of a business leader/ senior company executive). The aim is to increase awareness about such frauds to safeguard customers. In the Boss Scam, fraudsters impersonate senior leaders and trusted colleagues on social messaging apps to trick employees into making payments or sharing sensitive information. How does this scam work: Fraudsters send emails or messages on social media and messaging platforms, impersonating regulators or senior company executives such as CEOs and CXOs. The message typically claims that the organisation has violated some regulations, creating an urgency and pressuring the recipient to act quickly. The fraudsters share a ZIP file, supposedly containing compliance or security documents. When opened, it silently installs malware. The malware compromises the executive’s device (laptop / mobile), giving fraudsters access to their real social media messaging app account. Using the hijacked account, fraudsters send messages to the finance or accounts personnel, directing them to make urgent high-value transfers. In some cases, criminals save their own numbers under the CEO’s name on the compromised device, making fraudulent instructions appear completely legitimate. Customers should also file a complaint by calling 1930, a helpline number started by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) as well as submit a complaint on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal <https://www.cybercrime.gov.in>

#### The Nehru Science Centre organized the AI Prompt Art 2026 Exhibition from August 16 to 23, 2026



Celebrating Creativity, Imagination & India’s Journey into Space The Nehru Science Centre, Mumbai, in association with the National Centre for Science Communicators (NCSC), organised the AI Prompt Art Exhibition 2026 from August 16 to 23, 2026, as part of the National Space Week 2026 celebrations. The exhibition explored the intersection of art, science, technology and artificial intelligence, showcasing how AI could transform scientific ideas and imagination into visual stories. With the theme “India’s Lunar Exploration,” the exhibition featured artworks inspired by India’s Chandrayaan missions, lunar exploration, futuristic habitats and the Moon as a possible future home for humanity. The initiative received 210 entries from school students, college students and space enthusiasts. Thirty selected artworks were displayed at the exhibition, highlighting creative interpretations of lunar vehicles, the evolution of India’s lunar missions, and futuristic concepts such as lunar habitats, space agriculture and Moon transportation. The exhibition was inaugurated on August 16 at 1 p.m. by Dr Mayank Vahia, Scientist (TIFR, Retd.), along with other dignitaries. The exhibition aimed to encourage young minds and space enthusiasts to use emerging AI tools for creative scientific communication while dissolving the boundaries between science and art.

#### TMB Foundation Sponsors Classroom Construction to Advance Quality Higher Education at Loyola College, Chennai.



TMB Foundation has sponsored Rs. 25,00,000 towards the construction of a classroom at Loyola College, Chennai, as part of the institution’s centenary celebrations. The initiative commemorates 100 years of academic excellence and supports Loyola College’s ongoing infrastructure development to expand access to quality higher education. On 31 July 2026, Thiru Vincent Menachery Devassy, Executive Director, TMB Ltd., handed over the cheque to Rev. Fr. Antony Robinson, Rector and Vice President, Loyola College Society. The ceremony was graced by Mr. D. Inbamani, Vice President, TMB Foundation; Mr. P.R. Ashok Kumar, Executive Vice President, TMB Ltd.; Rev. Fr. D. Selvanayagam, Secretary-cum-Treasurer, Loyola College Society; Rev. Dr. A. Louis Arockiaraj SJ, Principal, along with senior faculty members of the college.

#### KRIBHCO Hazira Plant, Surat Celebrated 80<sup>th</sup> Independence Day with Patriotic Spirit



KRIBHCO Hazira Plant, Surat celebrated the 80th Independence Day with great patriotic spirit and enthusiasm on 15 August, 2026 at their open-air Ground. The celebrations commenced with the hoisting of the National Flag by Shri P. Chandra Mohan, ED (Operations) & Plant Head, followed by National Song- “Vande Mataram” and the National Anthem- presented by students of Kendriya Vidyalaya and by an impressive march past by Security Personnel and Kendriya Vidyalaya students. Addressing the employees and their families, Shri Chandra Mohan paid rich tributes to the freedom fighters and martyrs whose sacrifices secured India’s independence. He emphasised KRIBHCO’s responsibility towards building a strong, self-reliant and Atmanirbhar Bharat, highlighting that the organisation’s service to India and its farmers is a national calling. He reiterated KRIBHCO’s four commitments—Safety, Integrity, Excellence and Innovation—and called upon everyone to contribute towards a stronger KRIBHCO and a stronger India. The programme also featured colourful cultural performances by children and distribution of employee performance, long-service and educational awards. The celebrations concluded with a spirited Tiranga Yatra, reinforcing the spirit of unity and patriotism.



QUICKLY.

**Crude oil gains as US ramps up pressure on Iran**



Oil prices edged higher on Friday and were on track for a second straight weekly gain after the United States threatened to impose the toughest sanctions in history. Brent crude futures rose 19 cents to \$93.97 a barrel by 1202 GMT. US West Texas Intermediate crude was up 14 cents at \$86.97. REUTERS

**OMSS: Govt offers broken rice at ₹2,100/quintal**

**Bengaluru:** The Union government has fixed reserve price of ₹2,100 per quintal for the sale of broken rice to all under the Open Market Sale Scheme-Domestic (OMSS-D) for the July-September quarter. The announcement follows the outcome of the Dynamic Reserve Price Committee meeting held on August 20. OUR BUREAU

**Copper rebounds on weaker dollar**



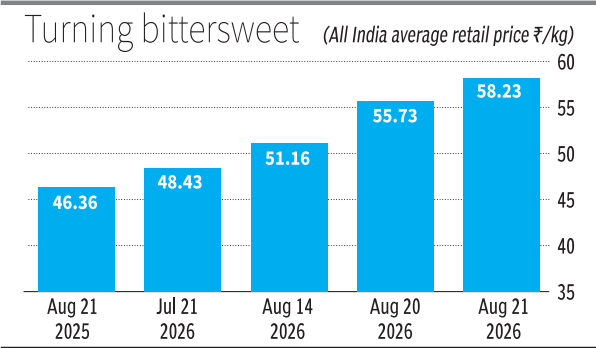
**London:** Copper prices rose on Friday, supported by a weaker dollar and top metals consumer China pledging fiscal policy measures to strengthen economic growth. Benchmark three-month copper on the London Metal Exchange was up 1.4 per cent at \$14,233 a tonne. Copper hit a six-month peak of \$14,396 on Monday. REUTERS

# ‘Resale’ sugar price drops as retail rates soar

**CORRECTION PHASE.** ₹400-500/qtl price decline likely to reach retail outlets early next week as govt tightens monitoring and traders book profits

**Subramani Ra Mancombu**  
Chennai

Resale sugar prices in India, particularly in Karnataka and Maharashtra, dropped by ₹400-500 a quintal on Friday, following the government's decision to permit import of 1 million tonnes of raw sugar. “There was no demand due to fears of heavy resale pressure on concerns over import of raw sugar. GST and Food Department officials tightened monitoring, while some traders indulged in profit booking,” an industry source told *businessline*. Resale sugar refers to sugar that traders or agents previously purchased from factories through tenders at ₹5,500 to ₹5,800 per quintal but have not lifted yet. “After tender rates exceeded ₹6,000, traders are selling this stock below Thursday’s market price, following government orders on price control. They are doing this to quickly realise profits due to restrictions.



Source: Department of Consumer Affairs

Still, some mills have kept the open rate of more than ₹6,400-6,500,” said the source. Prices are under pressure, and there could be a further drop of ₹100-200 from the ₹400-500 a quintal witnessed in the morning.

**RETAIL RATES ₹58.15/KG** However, retail prices soared to a new high of ₹58.15 a kg from ₹55.7 on Friday. “The drop in resale sugar prices will be reflected from tomorrow, if not Monday,” the source said, adding State

government and Food Department officials were intercepting vehicles for checking. “Warehouse inspection has begun in Karnataka and an unregistered warehouse has been sealed. Besides, bulk buyers are offloading their stocks in the open market after the Centre tightened stock holding norms,” a milling source said. While allowing raw sugar import, the government said in a notification that bulk buyers using over 10 tonnes

of sugar a month cannot hold more than 15 days’ stock. This will be in force till November 30.

**GLOBAL PRICES DIP** Global sugar prices, too, dropped after the government announced the import of raw sugar. October raw sugar futures, which surged to 18.26 cents a pound soon after the announcement, dipped to 17.35 cents at 1830 hours IST.

Raw sugar for cash was quoted at 17.5 cents. In London, white sugar slipped to \$548 a tonne from a surge to \$558 on Thursday. “Global prices were not expected to sustain as they factored in Indian imports,” said another trade source. On the other hand, the Ministry of Food asked all mills to furnish details of the sugar sold by them on August 17, 18 and 19. “This is to know who has bought sugar during these days and the volume purchased. The objective is to

crack the whip if it suspects someone,” said Dilip S Patil, Managing Director of Samarth SSK Ltd and Co-Chairperson of the Sugar Bioenergy Forum, under the Indian Federation of Green Energy.

**DGFT NORMS** Late on Thursday, the Directorate-General of Foreign Trade came up with norms to import raw sugar. It said preference will be given to importers who undertake to bring in consignments by October 15. It said for every 1.05 tonnes of raw sugar imported, the holder of the tariff quota licence should produce 1 tonne of white sugar. Trade sources said nearly 4 lakh tonnes (lt) could reach Indian shores within 45 days, with 3 lakh tonnes already on the way. Late on Friday, the government blamed sugar production being lower than initial estimates for the price surge. “Sugar production during the current season

(October 2026-September 2027) is expected to be around 306 lt, compared to the initial estimate of around 343 lt by sugarcane-growing States,” it said.

**ETHANOL NOT A REASON** Production was affected by red rot and top borer disease in sugarcane, as well as waterlogging caused by excess rainfall. “Despite the lower-than-estimated production, adequate sugar stocks are available in the country to meet domestic demand until the new crushing season begins in October,” it said. It denied that sugar prices had surged due to diversion for ethanol. “The share of sugar diverted for ethanol has declined from around 12 per cent in 2022-23 to around 9 per cent in 2025-26. Moreover, nearly three-fourths of the ethanol produced in the country now comes from grains, particularly maize,” the government said in a statement.

Despite duty-free window, India rules out sugar import from Pak

**Amiti Sen**  
New Delhi

India will not allow sugar imports from Pakistan despite its decision to permit duty-free imports of raw sugar to augment domestic supplies, with the government signalling that the existing trade restrictions with Islamabad will continue to apply. “India’s position and policy related to Pakistan is well known,” External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a media briefing on Friday, responding to a question on reports that Pakistani sugar producers were keen to supply to the Indian market. The clarification comes amid a sharp rise in domestic sugar prices and concerns over tightening supplies. The Centre has decided to allow duty-free imports of 1 million tonnes of raw sugar to improve availability and moderate prices. Pakistan’s sugar industry has reportedly urged its government to explore the possibility of exporting sugar to India following the Indian decision to open up duty-free imports. However, New Delhi is not considering an exception to the trade curbs imposed on Pakistan. On Wednesday, Islamabad floated a global tender to sell 1.05 lakh tonnes of sugar. “If India needs more sugar, there are enough options available in the global market. We don’t need to source from Pakistan,” a source said. The 1 mt duty-free window is expected to provide Indian refiners and traders access to alternative overseas supplies. For Pakistani sugar producers, the Indian market would have offered a significant nearby outlet.

## Gold rallies on weak dollar, top ₹1,60,000/10 g

**Our Bureau**  
Mumbai

Gold prices continued their uptrend and crossed ₹1,60,000 per 10 g as the dollar weakened against key currencies in the global markets and volatile treasury yields in the US. Opening on a firm trend, gold prices gained by ₹3,540 per 10 g to hit a high of ₹1,60,620 against the previous close of ₹1,57,080, according to data from the India Bullion and Jewellers Association. Silver prices also rallied to ₹2,46,630 per kg against the previous close of ₹2,37,766,

it added. MCX gold prices jumped over 1.3 per cent to cross ₹1.61 lakh per 10 g, while MCX silver prices surged 1.8 per cent to move above ₹2.47 lakh per kg. In fact, MCX gold has gained over ₹7,100 per 10 g, or around 5 per cent in three sessions. MCX silver, meanwhile, has risen by more than ₹15,000 per kg, marking a gain of nearly 7 per cent.

**GLOBAL RATES** Gold surged one per cent to \$4,620 an ounce on the Comex, hitting its highest level since May, when prices hovered around just \$4,659 per ounce. Silver has also



strengthened, reflecting renewed buying interest across the precious-metals complex. The rally in gold and silver prices were driven by a com-

bination of factors, including weak dollar, changing US bond yields, geopolitical tensions and growing concerns over the US fiscal position. **BEHIND THE SURGE** US debt has crossed \$40 trillion, while the Treasury has announced larger long-duration bond buybacks of at least \$4 billion per operation, which initially pushed yields and the dollar lower, and supported precious metals. This apart, the simmering US-Iran tensions have strengthened safe-haven demand for precious metals. Central banks have purchased nearly 289 tonnes of

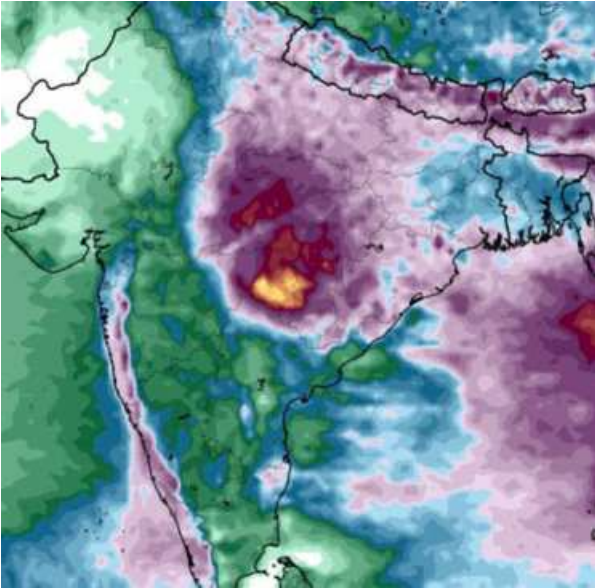
gold in the second quarter of 2026, up 62 per cent from a year earlier, highlighting the strength of underlying demand for the precious metal. Manav Modi, Commodities Analyst, Motilal Oswal Financial Services, said gold prices traded near their highest levels in more than two- and-a-half months as investors balanced support from lower bond yields against renewed concerns over inflation and rising fiscal risks. “However, the relief proved temporary, with the 30-year Treasury yield rebounding as concerns resurfaced over the sustainability of US government finances

after the total federal debt surpassed \$40 trillion,” Modi said. Kavita Chacko, Research Head, India, World Gold Council, said domestic gold prices remain below import parity, indicating local supply availability. Market feedback suggested that the exchange of old gold for new jewellery had increased market supply and kept prices at a discount to the landed cost. While discounts narrowed from about \$100 an ounce in mid-May to about \$45 an ounce in mid-August, they remained above July’s average \$34 an ounce, Chacko said.

## Monsoon loses punch under El Nino shadow

**Vinson Kurian**  
Thiruvananthapuram

The monsoon, after spending much of its recent energy over Eastern and Northern India, is showing signs of a quieter fortnight as El Nino is forecast to strengthen rapidly over the equatorial and eastern Pacific. Rainfall over India, as a whole, is likely to remain below normal from August 20 to September 2, according to the latest extended-range forecast of the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The outlook is broadly in line with a weather trend reported in *businessline* a few days ago. The monsoon depression that anchored the rain-bearing system over East and North-East India, as well as over parts of Central and North-West India, has weakened into a well-marked low-pressure area and is expected to weaken further into a conventional ‘low’. Its remnant cyclonic circulation, however, could linger over East India



**RAIN ALERT.** While East and Central India may hog the show with the maximum rainfall until Wednesday next, the West Coast, too, may join the party, per the ECMWF

through the coming week, keeping the rain machine ticking over parts of the region. **RAIN HEADS SOUTH** While East and North-East

the South Peninsula could emerge as surprise beneficiaries. Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal may receive isolated heavy rain on Monday and Tuesday, while Kerala and Mahe could see isolated heavy rain on Sunday and Monday. Coastal Karnataka, meanwhile, is likely to remain under a more persistent wet spell, with fairly widespread to widespread rain forecast for five days from Friday. The weather story changes again in the week beginning Thursday (August 27). The IMD expects the western Himalayan region to become a major focus, with isolated heavy to very heavy rain over Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand on several days, and isolated heavy rain over Jammu and Kashmir. East and North-East India are likely to receive light to moderate and fairly widespread to widespread rainfall. Konkan, Goa and coastal Karnataka may receive widespread rainfall, with isolated heavy falls on some days during the week.

## Soybean oil imports may surge during festival season, says SEA President

**Our Bureau**  
Mangaluru

Soybean oil imports could jump sharply in August due to various factors, according to Sanjeev Asthana, President of the Solvent Extractors’ Association of India (SEA). In his monthly letter to SEA members, he said India’s soybean oil import story is turning red-hot ahead of the festival season. “Competitive international prices, strong domestic demand and disruption in sunflower oil shipments amid the Russia-Ukraine conflict are prompting Indian refiners to step up purchases. According to trade estimates, soybean oil imports could touch 6.2 lakh tonnes (lt) in August, a potential monthly record and nearly 46 per cent above the current marketing year’s monthly average of 4.25 lt,” he said.

With sunflower supplies facing disruption and palm oil competing for market share, soybean oil is emerging as the preferred alternative. He said: “For India, however, the bigger question remains — how long can rising domestic demand continue to be met through imports while domestic soybean acreage and production face weather-related uncertainties?” **ACREAGE, A CONCERN** Stating that acreage had been a concern due to El Nino, Asthana said India’s total kharif oilseed acreage stood at 184.46 lakh hectares (lh) as of August 14, marginally below 185.36 lh last year. Groundnut, sesame and sunflower had shown encouraging acreage gains, while soybean had slipped to 120.84 lh from 122.61 lh. Castor has seen a sharper decline. With the sowing window progressing, the focus now shifts from acreage to

crop condition, yields, weather and ultimately farmer returns. **EXPORTS VALUE UP** During April-May 2026, edible oil exports stood at 41,438 tonnes, valued at ₹720.85 crore, compared with 49,100 tonnes, valued at ₹707.09 crore, a year earlier. While volumes declined by around 16 per cent, export value increased by nearly 2 per cent, suggesting better value realisation. Asthana said groundnut oil led the export basket, followed by soybean oil and sunflower oil. Looking at the oilseed trade, it certainly presents both opportunities and concerns. During April-May 2026, India exported 1.52 lt of oilseeds valued at ₹1,877.50 crore, with groundnut and sesame leading the exports. At the same time, oilseed imports surged to 4.31 lt worth ₹2,284.93 crore, with

soybean seed alone accounting for 4.13 lt. He said the sharp rise in soybean seed imports highlights the need to improve domestic productivity and ensure adequate availability of quality seed. Higher soybean imports also reflect lower stock levels in the country. **RBI ON EDIBLE OIL** He said the Reserve Bank of India’s observations on the diversion of edible oils from food to fuel add another important layer to the outlook. The global shift towards biofuels, particularly the increasing use of palm oil and other vegetable oils for biodiesel, had the potential to tighten export availability and keep international edible oil prices structurally firm. For India, one of the world’s largest edible oil importers, this has direct implications for the import bill, domestic prices and food inflation, he added.

## Ahead of Onam, tea prices rule firm at Kochi sales

**Our Bureau**  
Kochi

The absence of sales next week on account of the Onam holidays has pushed tea prices up at the Kochi auctions, with both CTC dust and leaf varieties witnessing firm demand. According to auctioneers Forbes, Ewart & Figgis, demand for CTC dust remained strong at sale 34. Good liquoring teas were steady to firm, with prices in some cases rising by ₹1-2 per kg. Of the 7,35,423 kg offered, blenders together accounted for 71 per cent of the total CTC quantity sold. Orthodox leaf also witnessed strong demand, with 94 per cent of the 2,56,527 kg

offered being sold. The average price realisation increased by ₹3 to ₹180 a kg this week. The whole leaf market was firm to dearer by ₹5-10 and, in some cases, even higher. Buyers from the CIS countries remained active, while West Asia provided fair support to the market. **ORTHODOX TEAS** Anil George Joseph, President, Tea Trade Association of Cochin, said orthodox teas witnessed good demand, particularly for blacker, well-made whole-leaf grades and larger, firm types, which were firm to occasionally dearer. Overall, the market remained quality-driven and selective.

## ‘Maharashtra offers the highest sop for solar pumps’

**Subramani Ra Mancombu**  
Chennai

Maharashtra farmers enjoy an advantage in installing solar pumps as the State subsidises a major portion of the cost, according to Gopal Kabra, Chairman & Managing Director, GK Energy. “This is due to the policy drive by the State government. In Maharashtra, if you are a farmer belonging to the open category, you have to spend 10 per cent of the installation cost. If you belong to the reservation category, you need to spend 5 per cent of the costs,” said the Pune-based firm’s CMD in an on-line interaction with *businessline*. In Uttar Pradesh, farmers have to bear around 30 per cent of the installation costs, while in Haryana, they have

to bear 20-25 per cent. In Madhya Pradesh, farmers have to bear 40 per cent of the costs. **EXTRA INITIATIVE** “In Maharashtra, the State government took the extra initiative, and they have expanded. It offers 60 per cent subsidy,” said Kabra. Subsidy for solar pumps is not given for the sake of it. “It is a cash profit from day 1. A new connection to a farm requires around ₹1.2-1.4 lakh capital expenditure, besides the cross-subsidy burden as power has to be given free of cost,” he said. Besides, every State has to fulfil renewable purchase obligation (RPO) for conventional connection. A solar pump is a perfect solution for all of these. These costs are higher than installing a solar pump.



Gopal Kabra, Chairman & Managing Director, GK Energy

“With this calculation, Maharashtra has begun providing higher subsidy to farmers to implement solar pumps on a mass scale. This has resulted in reducing the load on transformers and other places. The maintenance cost on rural infrastructure has been reduced,” said the GK Energy CMD, who has been Secretary of the

Solar Thermal Power Federation of India. **GUINNESS RECORD** As a result, over 15 lakh solar pumps have been installed in Maharashtra, with GK Energy accounting for 1.7 lakh of them. This helped Maharashtra enter the Guinness World Records on December 5, 2025, for installing 45,911 off-grid solar agriculture pumps in 30 days. The installations were done under the PM-KUSUM and Magel Tyala Saur Krushi Pump Yojana schemes to boost farm irrigation. Kabra said water availability has helped them to grow 2-3 crops. In addition, they get quality power unlike when they are connected to the electricity grid. This has also helped grow the farmers’ income.

## Patent for affordable millet rotimaker design

**Our Bureau**  
Hyderabad

Researchers from VNR Vignana Jyothi Institute of Engineering & Technology (VNR-VJIE), Hyderabad, in collaboration with the Indian Institute of Millets Research (IIMR), have secured an industrial design patent for an indigenous automated roti-making machine, developed specifically for millet rotis. The machine aims to address the time- and labour-intensive process of preparing millet rotis, which has been a key barrier to their wider adoption. **MAKEOVER** “The innovation aims to make millet roti preparation

faster, more convenient and accessible for Indian households. With young Indians increasingly embracing healthier lifestyles and food choices, the patented innovation seeks to bring greater convenience to millet consumption while advancing home-grown food-processing technology,” said Pranavanand Satyamurthy, lead researcher and Head of the Department of Electronics and Instrumentation Engineering, VNRVJIE. NUTRI-Hub, the IIMR’s incubation hub, provided ₹3 lakh in funding for the prototype and design development. The researchers aim to bring down the machine’s cost to around ₹40,000, compared with current models priced about ₹1.5 lakh.



QUICKLY.

**HDFC Bank raises \$1.75b via overseas bond issue**

**New Delhi:** HDFC Bank has raised \$1.75 billion through overseas bonds to fund its business growth. HDFC Bank, acting through GIFT City Branch, has completed the issue of \$1.75 billion in senior unsecured bonds, the bank said. This is the largest-ever fundraising by an Indian bank since the global financial crisis, and the issue generated interest from investors across Asia, the US, and Europe. **PTI**

**CSL delivers third anti- submarine vessel**

**Kochi:** *Mangrol*, the third of eight anti-submarine warfare shallow water craft, indigenously designed and constructed by Cochin Shipyard Ltd, was delivered to the Navy on Friday. Designed and constructed in accordance with the classification rules of DNV, the warship is equipped to undertake a range of critical maritime missions, including underwater surveillance, search and rescue operations and low intensity maritime operations. **OUR BUREAU**

**Mangaluru railway region to fully come under SWR**

**Mangaluru:** Mangaluru railway region, which is currently divided across South Western Railway (SWR) Zone and Southern Railway (SR) Zone, will be brought under the Mysuru division of SWR with effect from October 1. Brijesh Chowta, Member of Parliament from Dakshina Kannada, announced this through a post on X. “Mangaluru area upto Ullal (inclusive) to be transferred from Palakkad division of SR to Mysuru division of SWR. The interchange points between SWR and SR will accordingly shift from Padil to Ullal,” the Railway Board letter said. **OUR BUREAU**

# MGNREGA was a salutary scheme, neither a freebie nor exploitation: SC

**VERY EFFECTIVE.** It did a wonderful job in rural areas and was implemented pan-India, notes CJI Surya Kant

**Krishnadas Rajagopal**  
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday heaped praise on India's former national employment guarantee law, Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), calling it a “salutary scheme” which was neither a freebie nor exploitation of rural workers. The accolade from the court has come even as civil rights groups claim that the Centre's new law, the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) or the VB-G RAM G Act has seen a 50 per cent decline in employment generation compared to MGNREGA despite hiking guaranteed work days from 100 to 125 for every household in a year. The new law has shifted



**TOP DOWN.** The new law has shifted from a demand-driven rights-based framework to a centrally-controlled model

from a demand-driven rights-based framework to a centrally-controlled model. It has also seen a three-fold increase in States' funding burden, from a 90:10 ratio to 60:40. “MGNREGA was a good, effective scheme. It did a wonderful job in rural areas, and was implemented pan-India. It was neither freebie nor exploitation,” Chief Justice of India Surya Kant,

heading a three-judge Bench, orally observed. The Bench was hearing a petition filed by activist Aruna Roy seeking directions for the government to pay delayed wages under the MGNREGA, along with compensation for the delay. **EXAMINE THE LAW** Advocates Prashant Bhushan, Cheryl D'souza and Neha Rath, for Roy,

## Court rebukes ED for delay in Vadra case, seeks clear updates

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has sought more time from a Delhi court to complete its investigation into real estate developer DLF's role in the controversial Shikohpur land deal involving businessman Robert Vadra, the husband of Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra. Submitting a status report in a sealed cover before special judge Sushant Changoatra at the Rouse Avenue Court on Friday, the central agency stated that the probe into the real estate giant's

connection to the transaction is ongoing. Both Vadra and senior ED counsel Zohab Hossain and Special Public Prosecutor NK Matta attended the proceedings via video link. The court expressed displeasure with the agency's progress, pointing out that the ED failed to answer a specific query raised on April 15 regarding defence arguments made by Vadra's legal team. **DEMANDS ANSWER** Special judge Changoatra directed that the next status report address the query directly and be personally submitted by a Deputy Dir-



ector of the agency. The court granted the extension, setting the next hearing for September 23, while giving the agency three weeks to hand over the list of unrelayed documents to the defence. The ED also filed a

translation certificate for a key sale deed executed in Gujarat. Special Public Prosecutor for the ED had submitted that the translated copy of the said sale deed shall be filed on the next date of hearing. The money laundering probe stems from a 2018 Haryana Police FIR over a 3.5-acre plot in Shikohpur, Gurugram. Investigators allege Vadra-linked M/s Sky Light Hospitality bought the land in 2008 for ₹7.5 crore without paying the full amount upfront, using political clout under then-Chief Minister Bhopinder Singh Hooda to secure a commercial development licence. The plot was subsequently sold to DLF for ₹58 crore. The ED claims this ₹58 crore generated through a joint venture constitutes proceeds of crime, which were then routed through entities tied to Vadra. The court had summoned Vadra, who holds up to a 99 per cent stake in key accused entities, earlier this year after taking cognisance of the ED chargesheet. Vadra was granted bail on May 16. Earlier, the court had issued summons to Vadra and others on April 16 after taking cognisance of the ED's chargesheet against him and others.

issue a mandamus to implement MGNREGA or VB-G RAM G. Bhushan said the right to lead a dignified life was part of Article 21. **WAGE VS JOBS** “A dignified life requires you to get employment at minimum wages. Anything below minimum wages is forced labour,” Bhushan submitted. Justice Bagchi said a threshold for minimum wages may also run the risk of employments shrinking. Chief Justice Kant said wages would be linked to the local conditions. Justice V Mohana said the issues raised by Bhushan must be examined afresh in the light of the new law, and not under the MGNREGA. “We have to see fresh details, fresh statistics,” Justice Mohana said.

## Kamarajar Port floats tender for ₹4,288 cr second container terminal in PPP mode

**TE Raja Simhan**  
Chennai

Kamarajar Port Ltd (KPL) on Thursday issued a tender to develop its second container terminal at an estimated cost of ₹4,288 crore under the public-private partnership (PPP) mode. In line with the Kamarajar Port Ltd Master Plan for 2047, the second terminal is proposed to encourage more competition and prepare for future demand, it said. The plan is to develop the terminal to handle vessels up to 24,000 TEUs with a maximum LOA of 400 m, said the project feasibility report. The terminal will be developed on a design, build, finance, operate and transfer (DBFOT) basis with a 40-year concession period. The project aims to meet growing export-import and transshipment demand and strengthen Kamarajar Port's

position as a container-handling hub. **2 MILLION TEUS** The proposed terminal will have a total capacity of 2 million TEUs per annum and will be developed in two phases. Phase I, estimated at ₹2,429 crore, will provide 1.1 million TEUs of capacity, while Phase II will add 0.9 million TEUs at an estimated cost of ₹1,858.94 crore. The project involves construction of a 900 m continuous quay, with 500 m planned in Phase I and the remaining 400 m in Phase II. The facility will be designed to handle ultra large container carriers of up to 24,346 TEUs. The selected concessionaire will undertake the design, engineering, financing, procurement, construction, operation and maintenance of the terminal. The scope includes pile berths, container stack

yards, internal roads, administrative buildings, a customs gate complex and utility infrastructure. **50 MT CARGO** Kamarajar Port, located about 24 km north of Chennai Port, currently has a cargo handling capacity of 58.44 million tonnes across nine operational berths. It handled 49.08 million tonnes during FY25-26. The first container terminal is operated by Adani Ennore Container Terminal Pvt Ltd under the DBFOT model. The port has connectivity to major highways, including NH16, NH32 and NH48, as well as rail connectivity via Attipattu and Attipattu Pudunagar stations on the Chennai-Gudur section of Southern Railway. Kamarajar Port operates nine berths through a combination of captive, BOT, DBFOT and port-operated terminals.

## Centre denies approval to Telangana CM for US visit

**Our Bureau**  
Hyderabad

The Union Ministry of External Affairs has denied political clearance to Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy, who is leading a Telangana Rising delegation, to visit the US. The State government had sought the Centre's permission for the trip to the UK and the US, but only the UK trip was approved. The Centre informed the State of its refusal of permission after the delegation reached the UK. Reacting to the move, Reddy said in a release, “The only purpose of the visit was to, as part of the New Education Policy of the Centre, bring the world's best institutions to India, to Telangana, to Hyderabad. They would have been an answer to our youth's aspirations to get education, skills, and

training from the best Ivy League and top global institutions.” **CM WILL NOT GO TO US** While being “shocked” by the denial, Reddy will return to India from London, the release said. However, the Chief Minister has instructed his officials to go ahead with the US trip and conclude all the MoUs and partnership agreements. “We will make Hyderabad a global knowledge hub,” he said. In the UK, Reddy will continue, as per the scheduled programme, his visit to Oxford, Cambridge, the London School of Economics, the London Business School and the University of London, among others. He will also meet top sports institutions and skilling leadership in the United Kingdom, and try to formalise partnerships for Telangana.

## Holtec Intl keen to set up small modular reactors making facility in Gujarat

**Our Bureau**  
Ahmedabad

US-based nuclear technology company Holtec International has expressed interest in setting up a manufacturing facility for small modular reactors (SMRs) and a research and development centre in Gujarat, as the State seeks to build a domestic ecosystem for nuclear power equipment. The development came during Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel's meeting with Holtec International's leadership in New York, as part of his five-day US visit ahead of the Vibrant Gujarat Summit 2027. Patel told Holtec that the State government had identified nuclear power equipment, including SMRs, as a thrust area under Gujarat's newly announced Industrial Policy 2026. The proposed



investment could add a new dimension to Gujarat's growing manufacturing base in the energy sector, particularly as India looks to expand nuclear capacity and develop newer reactor technologies, the State government said in a release on Friday. The Gujarat government has not disclosed the proposed investment size, location or timeline for the SMR manufacturing facility or R&D centre. Patel's meeting with Holtec was part of a series of one-to-one meetings with

global companies during his US visit. **STATE OPPORTUNITIES** The Gujarat CM also held a one-to-one meeting with Samara Cohen, Senior Managing Director and Global Head of Development at BlackRock, where discussions centred on the growing opportunities for exchange-traded funds and asset management in India. In another meeting, Xerxes Cooper, Global Head of Delivery at Kyndryl, expressed interest in working with the State government on AI strategies, knowledge sharing, skilling and mentorship for startups and students. Patel highlighted Gujarat's growing presence in semiconductors, electronics, digital infrastructure, AI, data centres and advanced manufacturing, and invited Kyndryl to participate in the Vibrant Gujarat Summit.

## Amid strategic Ladakh tour, US envoy Sergio Gor visits Thiksey Monastery

**Gulzar Bhat**  
Srinagar

US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor visited the Thiksey Monastery in Leh on Friday to meet Buddhist monks and learn about the religious traditions that have shaped Ladakh's cultural life. Gor interacted with monks at the monastery, who briefed him on aspects of Buddhism and the role of monastic institutions in preserving the region's spiritual and cultural traditions, an official said. “The visit to Thiksey was part of the envoy's engagements during his first trip to Ladakh,” said an official. The monastery, one of the prominent Buddhist centres in the region, is known for its traditional architecture, religious artwork and hilltop

### His visit comes while the Dalai Lama is in Ladakh, leading to speculation about a possible meeting

location overlooking the Indus Valley. Gor arrived in Leh on Thursday after weather conditions disrupted his flight from Srinagar. Ladakh administration officials received him at the airport and escorted him to his hotel under tight security. During his visit, Gor also visited Nimmu, the meeting point of the Indus and Zaskar rivers, and took part in a river-rafting activity. His visit comes while the Dalai Lama is in Ladakh,

leading to speculation about a possible meeting between the US envoy and the Tibetan spiritual leader. There has been no official confirmation of any such meeting. Gor's Ladakh visit also comes against the backdrop of the region's strategic importance. Ladakh borders China and Pakistan, while eastern Ladakh has remained a sensitive security zone since the 2020 Galwan Valley clash and the military stand-off between India and China. Before travelling to Ladakh, Gor met Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah in Srinagar. During the meeting, he described Jammu and Kashmir as an important part of India and indicated that Washington could review its travel advisory for the region.

## Maharashtra FDA suspends licences of more eateries in south Mumbai

**Press Trust of India**  
Mumbai

The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has suspended the food business licences of the Bombay Presidency Radio Club and a McDonald's outlet in south Mumbai, along with 11 other food establishments across the State, for alleged violations of food safety and hygiene norms, officials said on Friday. The FDA is in the news since IAS officer Tukaram Mundhe took charge as Commissioner in May. **CLAMP DOWN** In a recent special drive, it inspected 89 hotels, restaurants and *dhabas*, issued improvement notices to 71 and suspended the licences of 13, an official release said.

## India's actuarial body targets 30,000 members by 2031, bets big on AI and climate risks

**Anupama Ghosh**  
Mumbai

The Institute of Actuaries of India (IAI) on Friday used Actuaries Day 2026 to launch a job portal and a brand bible, and to announce the 26<sup>th</sup> Global Conference of Actuaries, as the profession positions itself for an expanding role in India's financial sector. The event was addressed virtually by Debasish Prusty, Additional Secretary, Department of Financial Services, Ministry of Finance. IAI President Preeti Chandrashekhar, Vice President Anurag Rastogi, Honorary Secretary Asha Murali and Mike Lombardi, President of the International Actuarial Association, were present. IAI's membership has



The Institute of Actuaries of India has set a target of 30,000 members by 2031 while expanding its focus on AI, climate risks, data science and ESG as India's insurance market grows

reached 12,186 as of March 2026, its highest ever, with the institute targeting 30,000 members by 2031. The student base currently stands at 10,500. The number of institutions offering actuarial education has grown from 10 to 30, with a target of 100 by 2031. IAI also signed a MoU with

Bhimtech to collaborate on carbon markets and carbon credits, signalling a push into climate-linked financial risk, an area the institute's Education Policy 2026 now formally includes alongside data science, AI, and ESG. Prusty flagged AI adoption as both an opportunity and a compliance risk for the profession, calling on actuaries

to serve as “ethical gatekeepers” to monitor algorithmic bias, consumer data privacy, and institutional integrity. He described these three as a “trinity” of responsibilities. Chandrashekhar framed the profession's stakes in broader national terms. “Today's progress should not become tomorrow's vulnerability,” she said.

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**ANA extends suspension of Narita-Chennai flights**



**Chennai:** All Nippon Airways (ANA) has extended its suspension of the Narita-Chennai flight until March 27, 2027. It had suspended its operations from March 29 to October 24, 2026, and this has been extended, the airline said while announcing its revised flight schedule for the second half of FY26 that includes more international flights. **OUR BUREAU**

**Zydus gets US nod for ascorbic acid injection**

**New Delhi:** Zydus Lifesciences on Friday said it has received final approval from the US health regulator for its generic version of ascorbic acid injection used for scurvy. **PTI**

# FMCG firms seek AI solutions for fraud detection and compliance

**RISK-MONITORING.** Tighter FSSAI, FDA checks open ₹1,200 crore third-party risk management market

**Amit Vijay Mohile**  
Mumbai

Tighter FSSAI and State FDA checks and rising fraud risks across expanding supply chains are accelerating AI adoption among Indian FMCG companies. Hindustan Unilever, ITC, Nestle India, Tata Consumer Products, Dabur and Marico are among companies whose latest annual reports point to wider use of AI and digital tools across procurement, manufacturing, quality control, sales and supplier monitoring, although none separately discloses spending on AI-led fraud detection or third-party risk management. The direction of spending is nevertheless clear. Dabur and Marico explicitly refer to

Sectors that are growing faster typically tend to see more fraud. Industry that grows faster tends to attract more fraudsters

**AJAY TREHAN**  
Founder and CEO, AuthBridge



increased technology investments, while Nestle India provides some of the clearest evidence of technology being integrated into supplier-compliance and third-party risk processes. A Deloitte India survey separately found that 94 per cent of Indian enterprises expected AI expenditure to increase, 68 per cent identified security, compliance and

governance as a priority, and 48 per cent reported deploying AI at scale in supply-chain operations. The need is becoming more acute as FMCG and quick-commerce networks expand, multiplying the vendors, distributors, warehouses, merchants and workers that companies must police. Large retail and commerce companies such as

Tesco, Walmart and Swiggy, alongside FMCG manufacturers, are leaning on verification technology across three risk points — establishing whether vendors and distributors are genuine, verifying workers entering warehouses and delivery networks, and monitoring PS-SAI, food-safety and other statutory compliance across factories, warehouses and logistics operations.

**FRAUD RISKS** That broader technology push is showing up in the risks companies are asking such systems to detect. Ajay Trehan, Founder and CEO of verification technology company AuthBridge, said some large FMCG companies it works with have close to 50,000 third parties on their books, including

businesses onboarded years earlier without systematic re-verification. “Sectors that are growing faster typically tend to see more fraud,” Trehan told *businessline*. “Whichever industry grows faster tends to attract more fraudsters.”

AuthBridge estimates this shift is creating a ₹1,200-crore addressable third-party risk management market in India. Its own TPRM business currently generates around ₹20 crore, against overall FY26 revenue of just under ₹200 crore, but Trehan sees the vertical potentially reaching ₹200 crore within one-to-two years and ₹400 crore in three years — illustrating how sharply technology providers expect demand for continuous fraud and compliance monitoring to expand



## Crypto investors remain cautious despite Bitcoin price hitting \$72,000

**Vallari Sanzgiri**  
Mumbai

Young investors in the cryptocurrency space are recording a buy-to-sell ratio of 0.65, as per Q2 data, stressed by macro uncertainty and a preference to actively realise gains. Investors in the 18-25 year age group recorded the highest selling activity in Q2, as per data collated by Coin-Switch.

The trend weakened among investors aged 46 years and above, recording the highest buying conviction with a ratio of 1.14. “Age played an important role in shaping investment behaviour, with younger investors trading more actively while older investors demonstrated stronger buying conviction,” said Coin-Switch in its report.

**PREFERENCES SHIFT** When asked, Sharat Chandra, Founder, EmpowerEdge Ventures, said the trend is likely tied to the macro uncertainty and a preference to commit to corporate bonds or more traditional assets like gold. While Bitcoin picked up in August to \$72,000, Chandra remained unsure of whether the spike will affect the youth preference towards selling. “No one can say for sure if Bitcoin will keep rising but bond prices will continue to rise. The war is also not over yet. That uncertainty also hangs over the macro landscape. So no clear answers,” he said. Meanwhile, buying conviction strengthened progressively with age, with investors aged 26-35 recording a ratio of 0.9, 36-45 at 1.10, and 46 and above at 1.14, making the oldest cohort the strongest net buyers during the quarter.



## ‘Starlink’s entry into India will help rural connectivity’

**Vallari Sanzgiri**  
Mumbai

Satellite communication service provider Starlink will connect the hinterlands of India, Founder Elon Musk said in an X post on Friday even as the company continued to struggle with required approvals to start operations in the country.

“Starlink would help the least served in India, especially in rural areas,” said Musk, in response to another post on the platform that urged the government to grant required clearances to the company and connect remote villages, mountains, islands and disaster-hit areas. The development comes just as the satcom company

resubmits a request to India’s space regular to leverage its next-generation Gen 2 satellite constellation in the country. Musk’s attempt to portray satellite broadband as the connecting link in underserved areas aligns well with India’s digital-inclusion priorities. So, the rural push could improve political and regulatory optics, while helping Starlink position itself as complementary to Indian-backed players, as per Nithya S, Senior Analyst for Cloud and Infrastructure services at Everest Group.

However, the authorisation clearance will still depend on spectrum usage, security requirements, data routing, sovereignty and compliance with India’s



Elon Musk, CEO of Tesla and SpaceX **REUTERS**

satellite regulations. “The rural push helps the case around why India needs Starlink but does not make the regulatory hurdles around how Starlink operates any easier,” said Nithya.

**PRICING CHALLENGE** A rural focus also raises

questions of the company’s pricing strategy. India as a market is extremely crucial for satcom players like Starlink owing to their the sheer number of users in the hinterlands of India. The company has also subsidised prices in regions like Kenya at \$10 per month.

Considering the company is owned by one of the world’s richest persons, Starlink can afford to provide subsidised services to gain market share, said Mahesh Uppal, Director at CommFirst India,

“There are a number of places like oil rigs, where satcom is the only realistic option. While capex is high, the opex is very low. Unlike cellular satcom players do not have to pay exorbitant prices

for RoW infrastructure, beyond earth stations,” said Uppal. Even so, Everest Group estimated subsidies in India will still very selective and targeted. “Any government-backed subsidy for rural satellite access, should be seen as an upside rather than the foundation of Starlink’s India strategy,” said Nithya.

The global player also faces real competition with local service providers that already have enterprise relationships, terrestrial networks, and regulatory familiarity. Eutelsat OneWeb, backed by Bharti Airtel, is already targeting similar enterprise and remote-connectivity opportunities. Despite operating the largest satellite constellation in the world, Starlink also faces serious competition from Jio that can build its own LEO satellite capabilities and combine with its fibre, 5G/FWA, and enterprise connectivity services.

**MARKET VACUUM** Despite the hurdles, industry sources stress the inevitability of global satcom players entering India. Musk’s rural push only underlines that over 50 per cent of the Indian population remains net-unconnected. “Policy and regulation cannot stop tech especially if it is beneficial to customers. The rural areas offer 1-2 lakh crore of users that want broadband, not just dial-up connection. The market abhors a vacuum,” an industry source told *businessline*.

## Bengaluru departures to get cheaper, arrival fee rises

**Our Bureau**  
Bengaluru

Flying out of Bengaluru is set to become cheaper from September 1 as AERA’s new tariff order cuts the user development fee (UDF) for departing passengers by nearly 45 per cent.

Domestic flyers will pay ₹300, down from ₹550, while the international fee falls to ₹997 from ₹1,500.

However, the relief comes with a new charge for passengers flying into Bengaluru — ₹125 for domestic arrivals and ₹426 for international arrivals.

The revised tariff applies for 2026-31 and could reduce the airport-related cost of departing journeys, while adding a new expense for arriving passengers.

The change effectively shifts Bengaluru airport’s UDF model from one largely

**AERA justified the move on the grounds that airport infra is used by passengers at both ends of a journey**

borne by departing passengers to a structure that also charges those arriving at the airport.

AERA has justified the move on the grounds that airport infrastructure is used by passengers at both ends of a journey. Facilities such as aerobridges, travelers and baggage conveyor systems, for instance, serve both arriving and departing traffic.

The revised structure is part of a broader reset of airport charges for the new control period, which runs until March 31, 2031. While the

lower UDF could make outbound travel marginally cheaper, passengers arriving in Bengaluru will now have an additional airport charge built into their travel costs.

The order also introduces a significant change in how BIAL will recover the cost of some of its large upcoming infrastructure projects.

Under the incremental aggregate revenue requirement framework, the cost of identified high-value projects, including the proposed new terminal building and associated airside infrastructure such as a runway, apron and taxiway, will not be factored into the baseline tariff from the first year of the five-year control period.

Instead, the airport will be allowed to recover these costs through an incremental tariff once the respective assets are completed, commissioned and put to use. The approach is

intended to prevent passengers and airlines from paying upfront for infrastructure that is yet to become operational, while also linking tariff recovery to the actual delivery of the projects.

The framework was revised following concerns raised by the airport operator and other stakeholders, including over funding requirements, certainty around future incremental tariffs and the possibility of a sharp increase in tariffs when major projects are commissioned.

**FINAL ORDER** AERA said it had addressed these concerns in the final order, with the incremental tariff to be introduced through an addendum once the relevant projects become operational.

The regulator has also changed the charges levied on airlines. From September

1, domestic aircraft will be charged ₹325 per metric tonne for landing, while international aircraft will attract ₹455 per metric tonne, under the approved tariff framework.

For passengers departing on international flights, the airport will also levy \$1 towards common use terminal equipment, common use self-service and baggage reconciliation service facilities. Domestic departing passengers will pay ₹75 towards these facilities. The charges relate to shared terminal infrastructure, self-service systems and baggage reconciliation equipment.

AERA has, meanwhile, sought to use the tariff structure to support Bengaluru’s international connectivity. It has permitted a variable tariff plan under which airlines can receive landing-charge incentives if they meet specified conditions.

## As H1N1 cases rise, Health Minister reviews influenza preparedness

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

Amid a rise in H1N1 and other influenza cases, Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Friday reviewed the prevailing situation and preparedness to deal with seasonal influenza, with a particular focus on the National Capital.

Nadda reviewed the national surveillance and epidemiological situation, trends in influenza-like illness (ILI) and severe acute respiratory infections (SARI), testing and laboratory surveillance, and the preparedness of healthcare facilities to manage seasonal influenza cases. The preparedness of healthcare facilities in Delhi was also reviewed, including the

availability of hospital beds, critical-care facilities and essential supplies. Doctors said the current rise in influenza cases was not necessarily indicative of a more severe outbreak, but urged people to remain alert to warning signs and high-risk groups. Medical Superintendent of Holy Family Hospital Sumit Ray said that the case load is not huge but fairly large.

**VULNERABLE PATIENTS** Rakesh Gupta, Senior Consultant, Internal Medicine, Indraprastha Apollo Hospital, Delhi, said H1N1 activity is currently presenting predominantly through outpatient cases, with fever, cough, sore throat, body aches and fatigue being common features. He said doctors were particularly focused on identifying patients at risk of deterioration.

Rajesh Kumar, Director, Internal Medicine, Paras Health, Gurugram, said changing weather, fluctuating temperatures and high humidity could favour the transmission.

**DETECTING VIRUS** He said symptoms of H1N1 could overlap significantly with those of other respiratory infections. “Sudden fever, cough, sore throat, body ache, headache, chills, runny nose and marked fatigue are common symptoms,” he said. Kumar advised people with flu-like symptoms to stay home, maintain hygiene, ensure good ventilation and consider wearing a well-fitting mask.

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## ‘TV ad volumes slump 7% in Jan-July, top 10 account for 43%’

**Meenakshi Verma Ambwani**  
New Delhi

Television ad volumes dipped by 7 per cent in the January-July period this year compared with the same period last year, according to estimates released by TAM AdEx.

This indicated a phase of strategic recalibration in advertiser spending. Reckitt India, Hindustan Unilever and Godrej Consumer Products emerged as the top three advertisers on TV by ad volume.

The top 10 advertisers included Mondelez India, Coca-Cola India, Nestle India, P&G India, Wipro Enterprises, Britannia Industries and Google. They accounted for 43 per cent of ad volumes during the January-July period. “There was 9 per cent drop in January-July 2025



over January-July 2024, which shows that there was modest correction in ad volumes of January-July 2026,” the report noted.

**TOP FIVE** Soaps, floor and toilet cleaners, e-commerce (entertainment, social media and media), chocolates and toothpastes emerged as the top five most-advertised categories during this period.

Washing powders and liquids, biscuits, milk beverages, aerated soft drinks and

jewellery retail outlets were among the top 10 categories during the first half of the year.

“The top 10 categories together added 33 per cent share of ad volumes in January-July 2026 period. Biscuits was the new entrant among the top 10 categories during this period,” it added. Overall, food & beverage emerged as the top sector, with a 23 per cent share of overall ad volumes during this period, followed by services and personal care and hygiene.

General entertainment channels continued to lead with a 30 per cent share of ad volumes, followed by news channels at 25 per cent.

In fact, 150 categories witnessed an increase in ad volumes. The e-commerce category saw the highest increase in ad volumes, at almost 10.2 times, in the January-July period.

## Govt restricts chlorpheniramine, phenylephrine drugs for infants

**Our Bureau**  
New Delhi

The Centre on Friday imposed restrictions on the manufacture, sale and distribution of fixed-dose combination medicines containing chlorpheniramine maleate and phenylephrine hydrochloride for use in children below four years of age.

The notification states that the move has been taken in the public interest following recommendations from the Drugs Technical Advisory Board.

Under the new notification, manufacturers of these fixed-dose combination medicines must prominently carry the warning: “Fixed dose combination shall not be used in children below four years of age” on the drug label, package insert or promotional literature.

## Sun TV launches Sun NXT Shorts as media giant eyes entry into vertical content

**Rohan Das**  
Chennai

Media and entertainment conglomerate Sun TV Network has announced the launch of Sun NXT Shorts, a new offering for micro-drama and short-form content.

Built into its OTT platform Sun NXT, the offering will be launched with about 150 titles across all south Indian languages.

**EVEN MIX** It will have an even mix of original titles as well as Sun Network’s traditional movies and TV shows and other international titles that are re-formatted for vertical viewing.

The group plans to reimagine successful movies like *Endhiran*, *Ayan* and *Thiruchitrambalam*, alongside television serials like



Rakesh CK, Head, Sun NXT

*Ethirneechal*, *Kayal* and *Sundari*, into high frequency, episodic formats for modern ‘snackable’ consumption.

Speaking to *businessline*, Rakesh CK, Head, Sun NXT, said that while micro dramas and vertical content had been on the company’s radar for a while, it wanted to assess whether the segment could become a substantial business.

“Now that we have that clarity, I think we are entering into this space in a fairly

large way,” he said.

Sun TV Network’s entry comes at a time when multiple players in the industry have introduced and seen strong momentum in their vertical drama platforms like JioHotstar’s Tadka, ZEE5’s Bullet, Tata Play’s Shots and Amazon-owned MX Player’s MX Patafat.

Rakesh suggested that Sun TV’s expertise in creating content tailored for south Indian audiences would help the company differentiate itself from incumbents.

**HORIZONTAL CONTENT** As for how the company plans to reformat Sun TV’s extensive portfolio of horizontal content for this new format, he said that titles will be reworked such that the presentation is altered, and there is a greater emphasis on close-ups and personal shots. The shorts will initially be

made available for free to give users a taste of the platform and its content with subscriptions as the preferred monetisation route eventually.

“We have 65,000 hours of content, decades of storytelling equity, and a distribution network that no new entrant can build overnight. The opportunity is to take that asset base and reformat it for the next generation of consumption — not to chase a trend, but to define the category before someone else does,” Kavya Maran, Executive Director, Sun TV Network, said.

Interestingly, Sun TV’s foray into the vertical drama space comes at a time when the Maran Group, founded by Dayanidhi Maran, the brother of Sun TV Founder and Executive Chairman Kalanithi Maran, launched its own microdrama platform KadhaiShorts.







| Company | Prev | Close | Open | High | Low | Qty | 52WH | 52WL | PE | BSE CI | Company | Prev | Close | Open | High | Low | Qty | 52WH | 52WL | PE | BSE CI | Company | Prev | Close | Open | High | Low | Qty | 52WH | 52WL | PE | BSE CI | Company | Prev | Close | Open | High | Low | Qty | 52WH | 52WL | PE | BSE CI |
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|----------------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|----------|--------|--------|--------|-------|
| OIL India      | 480.90  | 475.00  | 480.00  | 482.00  | 475.00  | 1163.34  | 531.04 | 384.60 | 12     | 47.75 |
| Oil Electric   | 37.82   | 37.73   | 37.82   | 38.11   | 37.51   | 13595.38 | 71.24  | 21.21  | 37.73  |       |
| OilGreenGen    | 1291.20 | 1318.40 | 1297.00 | 1353.00 | 1297.00 | 86.334   | 71.24  | 174.20 | 86.66  |       |
| OM Infra       | 84.67   | 84.13   | 84.04   | 85.46   | 83.90   | 56.82    | 141.00 | 71.50  | 71.50  |       |
| OM Power TR    | 167.20  | 163.09  | 162.70  | 165.01  | 161.40  | 73.88    | 20.60  | 158.01 |        |       |
| OMAXE          | 106.61  | 102.55  | 102.03  | 105.00  | 101.13  | 1084.33  | 10.87  | 62.85  | 10.236 |       |
| Omasheng       | 574.00  | 581.00  | 574.45  | 583.00  | 573.00  | 76.41    | 15.15  | 40.58  | 62.85  |       |
| One PointOne   | 56.16   | 56.17   | 57.00   | 58.36   | 56.32   | 6.85     |        | 40.58  | 62.85  |       |
| ONEM Tech      | 302.65  | 303.05  | 303.01  | 305.12  | 302.55  | 162.61   | 31.50  | 190.00 | 62.85  |       |
| OneMobiW       | 195.66  | 196.81  | 196.50  | 198.50  | 195.80  | 51.16    | 34.00  | 151.46 | 190.00 |       |
| OneMobiSec     | 154.90  | 155.00  | 155.00  | 156.70  | 152.90  | 50.19    | 19.05  | 107.00 | 151.46 |       |
| ONGC [5]       | 238.50  | 236.20  | 238.70  | 239.22  | 236.40  | 1331.40  | 40.97  | 227.60 | 107.00 |       |
| ONIDA ELECTRO  | 36.67   | 36.66   | 36.55   | 37.10   | 36.26   | 49.24    |        | 49.23  | 21.50  |       |
| Optima Tech    | 225.50  | 225.50  | 225.50  | 225.50  | 225.50  | 30.71    | 28.65  | 20.19  | 49.23  |       |
| OPTIMUS        | 55.75   | 54.02   | 55.10   | 55.85   | 53.40   | 95.14    | 71.28  | 28.90  | 20.19  |       |
| ORACLE FIN [5] | 118.26  | 117.40  | 118.50  | 118.80  | 118.00  | 110.09   | 71.96  | 58.90  | 28.90  | 29.11 |
| Orchid Pk      | 980.05  | 1002.75 | 988.48  | 1026.94 | 979.24  | 106.27   | 113.00 | 480.00 | 58.90  |       |
| Orion Corp     | 115.28  | 115.28  | 115.28  | 115.28  | 115.28  | 115.28   | 115.28 | 115.28 | 480.00 |       |
| Orient Cera    | 41.73   | 45.63   | 47.78   | 48.24   | 45.00   | 17.40    | 55.64  | 34.00  | 115.28 |       |
| Orient Tech    | 186.03  | 185.08  | 185.95  | 186.99  | 183.66  | 122.38   | 21.80  | 149.05 | 34.00  |       |
| Orient Hotel   | 24.13   | 24.65   | 24.42   | 24.50   | 24.00   | 144.81   | 51.30  | 20.80  | 149.05 |       |
| ORIENTAL RAIL  | 103.63  | 114.78  | 108.98  | 124.35  | 104.25  | 114.23   | 14.23  | 102.80 | 20.80  |       |
| ORIENTRELL     | 120.20  | 125.45  | 125.45  | 126.00  | 125.00  | 37.00    | 45.35  | 37.05  | 102.80 |       |
| Orissa Min [1] | 465.61  | 467.50  | 478.00  | 480.00  | 463.00  | 461.80   | 10.00  | 46.30  | 37.05  |       |
| Orkla India    | 550.35  | 552.20  | 546.50  | 560.00  | 546.65  | 56.00    | 78.80  | 53.25  | 46.30  |       |
| OswalPumps     | 34.75   | 299.60  | 37.60   | 380.30  | 299.00  | 466.35   | 68.60  | 28.10  | 53.25  |       |

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| P&G Health   | 583.50 | 582.50 | 582.00 | 586.00 | 580.50 | 7.24   | 697.00 | 4707.00 |        |       |
| Pace Digitel | 175.37 | 180.69 | 175.45 | 181.90 | 174.14 | 120.22 | 25.39  | 139.81  |        |       |
| Page Ind     | 35.05  | 34.60  | 35.00  | 35.00  | 37.50  | 32.10  | 18.86  | 47.29   | 298.00 | 51.35 |
| P&G India    | 86.69  | 84.52  | 86.65  | 89.50  | 83.50  | 191.00 | 17.84  | 69.10   |        |       |
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| P&G India    | 86.69  | 84.52  | 86.65  | 89.50  | 83.50  | 191.00 | 17.84  | 69.10   |        |       |
| P&G India    | 86.69  | 84.52  | 86.65  | 89.50  | 83.50  | 191.00 | 17.84  | 69.10   |        |       |
| P&G India    | 86.69  | 84.52  | 86.65  | 89.50  | 83.50  | 191.00 | 17.84  | 69.10   |        |       |
| P&G India    | 86.69  | 84.52  | 86.65  | 89.50  | 83.50  | 191.00 | 17.84  | 69.10   |        |       |
| P&G India    | 86.69  | 84.52  | 86.65  | 89.50  | 83.50  | 191.00 | 17.84  |         |        |       |